

Cross-Ethnic Social Interactions and Multilevel Belonging Among First-Generation Immigrants in Quebec

Younghyun Lee¹ and Antoine Bilodeau²

¹Department of Political Science, University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign

²Department of Political Science, Concordia University

28th July 2026

Abstract

How do immigrants come to feel they belong in their new country? This paper examines how everyday social interactions, both with people from their own ethnic community and with people from different backgrounds, are associated with immigrant belonging. Using original survey data from 1,795 first-generation immigrants across 29 localities in Quebec, we show that the same kinds of interaction are associated with different forms of belonging depending on political context. We compare two contexts that the same immigrant population lives under: Canada's multicultural framework, which treats keeping one's ethnic identity as compatible with being Canadian, and Quebec's interculturalist framework, which expects immigrants to converge around a shared French-language public culture. Under Canada's framework, both kinds of interaction are associated with belonging in different ways: cross-ethnic friendship is associated with feeling accepted, and co-ethnic friendship is associated with feeling attached. Under Quebec's framework, only cross-ethnic interaction is associated with belonging; co-ethnic interactions are politically invisible. We also find that the costs of discrimination are largest in Quebec, where the demand to integrate is highest. The political context in which cross-ethnic recognition appears most consequential is also where exclusion is most costly.

Word Count: 8290

1 Introduction

Immigrants build relationships in many different ways. Some rely primarily on family members and people from their own ethnic community. Others develop relationships beyond their co-ethnic community through friendships and everyday interactions with people from different backgrounds. How do immigrants develop a sense of belonging through relationships within and beyond their co-ethnic communities? Belonging refers to how individuals see themselves in relation to others in the same community (Amit & Bar-Lev, 2015), and it encompasses both feelings of acceptance and feelings of attachment (Bilodeau et al., 2020). It is also central to immigrant integration, the mutual adaptation of immigrants and host communities (Bilodeau et al., 2020; Fuchs et al., 2021; Jiménez, 2011), and has important consequences for political incorporation, including political trust, democratic engagement, and identification with the host society (Schildkraut, 2005; Simonsen, 2021).

Existing research traces immigrant belonging to structural and institutional drivers (Hainmueller et al., 2015, 2017; Simonsen, 2017) and to features of the host-society context (Mayorga, 2021; Simonsen, 2019, 2021). Much less is known about how immigrants' everyday interactions, both within and beyond their co-ethnic communities, relate to their feelings of acceptance and attachment. Yet these interactions are among the most immediate ways in which immigrants encounter, navigate, and make sense of the societies in which they live. We argue that immigrants do not develop a sense of belonging through everyday interactions in the same way across political communities. Whether relationships within and beyond immigrants' co-ethnic communities are connected to feelings of acceptance and attachment depends on how immigrant integration is understood. We describe these contrasting approaches as *plus-sum* and *zero-sum* frameworks of integration. Under a plus-sum framework, relationships both within and beyond immigrants' co-ethnic communities can be associated with belonging, although they are connected to different dimensions of belonging. Under a zero-sum framework, by contrast, belonging is understood primarily through participation in a common public culture, making relationships beyond immigrants' co-ethnic communities more closely connected to belonging than relationships within them.

Canada and Quebec provide a unique setting to examine this argument. First-generation immigrants in Quebec live simultaneously under Canada's federal multicultural framework and Quebec's provincial intercultural framework, allowing us to examine how the relationship between everyday interactions and belonging varies across two approaches to immigrant integration while holding constant the immigrant population, immigration histories, and survey conditions. To do so, we draw on original survey data from 1,795 first-generation immigrants across 29 localities in Quebec. We distinguish between two forms of interaction within both bridging and bonding: self-selected friendship (strong ties) and opportunity-driven shared activities such as sports and cultural events (weak ties). We examine belonging at three levels: the neighborhood, an apolitical baseline shaped by proximity and routine; Quebec, the intercultural provincial community; and Canada, the multicultural national community. To capture the multidimensional struc-

ture of belonging, we analyze feelings of attachment (internal identification) and feelings of acceptance (perceived recognition) separately.

Immigrants with cross-ethnic friendships report stronger feelings of acceptance at the neighborhood, Quebec, and Canada levels, making this the most consistent finding in the paper. By contrast, immigrants with stronger co-ethnic friendships report stronger feelings of attachment to Canada, but not to Quebec. Immigrants who participate in cross-ethnic activities also report stronger feelings of acceptance in Quebec, but not in Canada. Finally, immigrants who perceive greater discrimination report the weakest sense of belonging in Quebec. The political context where cross-ethnic recognition matters most is also where exclusion is most costly. Together, these findings suggest that the relationship between everyday interactions and belonging differs not only across forms of interaction, but also across dimensions of belonging and political communities.

The paper makes three contributions. First, it advances research on immigrant integration by explaining why the relationship between everyday interactions and belonging differs across political contexts. Rather than reflecting measurement noise alone, conflicting findings on the consequences of co-ethnic and cross-ethnic interactions may also reflect meaningful differences in how political communities understand immigrant integration. Second, the paper brings subnational political contexts into the study of immigrant integration by showing that minority-nation frameworks, which remain understudied in the comparative political behavior literature, can produce different patterns of belonging than national frameworks. Third, it shows that the opportunities and constraints of integration are unevenly distributed across political communities. Where integration places greater emphasis on participation in a common public culture, immigrants benefit more from cross-ethnic interactions, while experiences of discrimination carry greater consequences for belonging. The 2019 fieldwork, conducted during Quebec's passage of Bill 21 restricting religious symbols in public service, provides a particularly valuable setting for examining the political stakes of belonging under a convergence-oriented framework.

2 Theory

Understanding how immigrants come to feel they belong in their host society requires three analytical moves. First, it requires distinguishing what belonging is, recognizing it as a multidimensional construct rather than a single feeling. Second, it requires specifying how different forms of everyday social interaction map onto these dimensions: whether a tie is bridging or bonding, and whether it is a self-selected friendship or an opportunity-driven shared activity, shapes which dimension of belonging it can reach. Third, it requires recognizing that belonging is structured by the political context in which immigrants find themselves, and that what counts as integrative behavior and what discrimination costs varies across those contexts.

2.1 The Multi-Dimensional Nature of Belonging

Belonging is the affective foundation of immigrants' incorporation into the host society's political community. Whether immigrants feel attached to that community, and whether they feel accepted by it, predicts the political trust, democratic satisfaction, and identification on which incorporation rests (Schildkraut, 2005; Simonsen, 2021). Belonging is also a multidimensional concept that can be conceived as encompassing both feelings of attachment ("the person experiences a fit or congruence with other people, groups, objects, organizations") and feelings of acceptance ("the person experiences being valued, needed, or important to other people, groups, and organizations") (Banting & Soroka, 2012; Hagerty et al., 1992). Bilodeau et al. (2020) further demonstrate that these two dimensions are independent yet complementary, each playing a distinct role in shaping immigrants' sense of belonging. While attachment captures how individuals engage with and perceive the host society, acceptance captures the individual's perception of how the community is reaching out to them (Bilodeau et al., 2020). The distinction matters politically: attachment and acceptance plausibly map onto different political outcomes, with attachment more closely tied to identification-based behaviors and acceptance to recognition- and trust-based ones.

Belonging is always anchored in place, and the places immigrants inhabit are politically layered. Immigrants live simultaneously in local, sub-national, and national political communities, each of which makes different demands and offers different forms of recognition (Bilodeau et al., 2022; Schildkraut et al., 2019b). As Yuval-Davis (2006) notes, it is a feeling directed toward a specific location, shaped by shared experiences, practices, and relationships with others who are seen as part of the same place. Belonging is also a layered experience (Toikko & Pehkonen, 2018). Thus, belonging is a multilevel relational process through which immigrants develop attachment and feel accepted in various layers of the host society. While daily routines and immediate interactions often occur at the local level (Wu et al., 2011), which is apolitical, they also encounter the sub-national level, which may introduce distinct cultural, linguistic, or political frameworks. Finally, they relate to the national level, which encompasses institutional policies, legal rights, and symbolic narratives of belonging. This national level may be viewed as their ultimate destination in terms of long-term integration and identification. These distinctions matter because the drivers of belonging are not uniform.

This combination of two dimensions at multiple levels has direct implications for how we should study immigrant belonging. The drivers of belonging are unlikely to be uniform across either axis. A given social interaction may generate feelings of acceptance without producing attachment, or vice versa. A given form of integration may matter at the national level but not the provincial level, or operate differently at the local level where political-institutional frameworks matter less than everyday proximity. The remainder of this section develops the central argument of the paper: that the political context structures which forms of social interaction are associated with which dimensions of belonging at which levels.

2.2 Belonging Through Social Interaction

How social interactions are associated with belonging depends on what kind of interaction and what kind of belonging is at stake. In this section, we develop two claims that together specify the mapping. The first claim is that bridging ties primarily carry signals of recognition from the host society, while bonding ties primarily carry emotional anchoring within the immigrant community. The second claim is that not all ties are equally deep. Friendship is sustained and personal, so it can reach both dimensions of belonging. Activities are structured, public, and intermittent, so they can reach acceptance but not the internal identification that attachment requires. Taken together, the two claims predict which form of social interaction can explain which dimension of belonging.

A central channel through which belonging develops is social interaction, which is the everyday interactions immigrants build with others. Classic contact theory (Allport, 1979) posits that under certain conditions — (1) equal status contact between majority and minority groups, (2) the pursuit of common goals, (3) supported by institutional structures, and (4) a shared perception of common interests and humanity — intergroup contact can reduce prejudice and promote mutual understanding. Empirical evidence from a wide range of contexts has confirmed these predictions: meta-analyses show that contact generally reduces prejudice even when Allport's optimal conditions are only partially met (Pettigrew & Tropp, 2006). Through repeated encounters, individuals gain more accurate information about outgroups, and replace stereotypes with personal experiences and recognize shared humanity (Alrababa'h et al., 2019; Skipworth et al., 2010).

However, much of the contact literature has focused on majority-group outcomes, examining how contact shapes natives' prejudice toward immigrants (Choi et al., 2022; Hangartner et al., 2019). Far less is known about what contact means for immigrants themselves. Unlike the majority population, minorities feel in a different way from the dominant groups because they are more attuned to their subordination (Oskooii, 2020; Pérez & Vicuña, 2023). Their experiences are less often characterized by the "equal status" condition envisioned by Allport. Even naturalized citizens may continue to face symbolic exclusion, as their visible minority status or migration background marks them as outsiders. Yet for immigrants, intergroup contact carries asymmetrical meanings: it represents both an opportunity for inclusion and a test of recognition within a host-society hierarchy (Prati et al., 2022; Simonsen, 2019). These asymmetries have direct political-behavior consequences: discrimination, exclusion, and the perception of being unwelcome shape immigrants' political trust, identification, and engagement in ways that majority-side contact research cannot capture (Lajevardi et al., 2020; Schildkraut, 2005; Simonsen, 2021).

Social capital theory extends this perspective by specifying that not all ties are alike. While the bonding/bridging distinction has been used to study economic outcomes (Lancee, 2010), a growing body of work also shows that social ties are associated with immigrants' and minorities' political-psychological outcomes more broadly (Roman et al., 2022; Sumaktoyo, 2021). Putnam et al. (2000) distinguishes between two forms of social capital: bonding and bridging. Bonding social capital refers to connections among similar indi-

viduals — those who share ethnic, racial, or cultural backgrounds — while bridging social capital links individuals to others who are socially different (Hannuksela & Tiihonen, 2024; Putnam et al., 2000). The two forms capture distinct but complementary dimensions of social life: bonding provides cohesion and emotional support within groups, whereas bridging fosters information flow, trust, and reciprocity across group boundaries (Panagopoulos et al., 2022). Early scholars often contrasted these two forms normatively. Bonding ties, although promoting solidarity and mutual assistance, have been criticized for reinforcing exclusivity and social divisions (Mc Kenzie, 2008; Putnam et al., 1993). Bridging ties, in contrast, are celebrated for their inclusivity and for connecting diverse individuals across lines of race, class, and ideology.

However, the consequences of bonding are more complex than the early scholars have suggested. In marginalized or minority communities, bonding social capital can be a critical resource for resilience, identity continuity, and political empowerment (Mc Kenzie, 2008). Mc Kenzie (2008) shows that bonding ties within African-American civic associations do not pull members away from broader civic and political life but instead connect them to it, and Sumaktoyo (2021) similarly demonstrates in the partisan context that bonding and bridging are independent constructs with distinct consequences rather than opposite ends of a single continuum. The relevance of this distinction is particularly evident in the case of immigrants. For immigrants, bridging social capital (interactions with natives or out-group members) represents a crucial form of host-society specific capital that facilitates adaptation, language acquisition, and social mobility (Lancee, 2010). It can signal recognition by the broader society and affirm immigrants as legitimate members of the community. The bonding/bridging distinction has been productive but underspecified in one important respect. Both forms of capital have typically been treated as having context-invariant effects: bonding is always inward-facing, bridging is always integrative. This treatment obscures the possibility that the meaning of each form of tie for immigrant belonging may depend on the political and institutional context in which the tie is formed. Before we turn to that argument, we introduce one further distinction within both bridging and bonding: the difference between self-selected friendship and opportunity-driven shared activities.

Friendship and participation in shared activities — such as sports teams, cultural organizations, or community events — are different kinds of social interaction even when they involve the same other people. This distinction draws on the classical sociological framework of strong and weak ties (M. S. Granovetter, 1973). Strong ties, such as friendships, are characterized by emotional intimacy, personal disclosure, a sense of uniqueness, and a high degree of voluntary investment (M. S. Granovetter, 1973; Sprecher, 2022). Weak ties, such as interactions with acquaintances or fellow participants in collective activities, involve less intimacy, fewer obligations, and more formal or role-based interaction (Fingerman, 2009; M. S. Granovetter, 1973; Sprecher, 2022).

This distinction brings important theoretical implications for the study of immigrant integration. Friendship is self-selected in that people actively choose their friends, which means that cross-ethnic friendship in particular reflects a deliberate openness to building

bonds across ethnic boundaries. Because of this, friendship-based contact may be subject to reverse causality; immigrants who already feel a greater sense of belonging or openness toward the host society may be more likely to form cross-ethnic friendship in the first place, rather than the other way around. Participation in shared activities, by contrast, is shaped more by availability than by individual preferences. Who else shows up to a community sports league or cultural event is largely outside any individual participant's control (Jørgensen, 2026). This makes activity-based contact less dependent on pre-existing attitudes toward other groups and therefore a more exogenous form of intergroup exposure. While M. Granovetter (1983) himself argued that weak ties are vital for social integration precisely because they connect individuals to circles beyond their immediate networks, recent work has shown that activity-based contact and friendship-based contact do not always produce the same effects: participation in mixed leisure organizations can generate cross-ethnic contact within the organization without translating into broader cross-ethnic friendship (Jørgensen, 2026).

For immigrants, the two forms of interaction likely are associated with belonging through different psychological channels. Friendship reflects deeper interpersonal recognition. Activities, by contrast, foster belonging through routine participation in shared spaces and practices, even when individual ties remain relatively weak. We return to this distinction in our hypotheses, where we predict that friendship and activities operate on different dimensions of belonging. The implication is direct. If cross-ethnic interactions signal that the host society recognizes immigrants as members, while co-ethnic interactions provide emotional anchoring and community continuity, then the two forms of social interaction should map onto different dimensions of belonging. Cross-ethnic interactions, by signaling personal recognition from members of the host society and connecting immigrants to its institutions, should operate primarily on the acceptance dimension — the perception of being valued by the host community. Co-ethnic interactions, by providing fit, congruence, and emotional embeddedness within an immigrant community, should operate primarily on the attachment dimension — the felt sense of belonging to a place and a people.

2.3 When Do Bonding and Bridging Ties Generate Belonging?

The bonding/bridging distinction and the friendship/activities distinction both describe forms of social interaction, but neither tells us when each form should be related to belonging at the level of the political community. To answer that question, we have to bring the host society back in. The political context in which immigrants form social ties shapes what those ties mean (Bilodeau et al., 2022; Schildkraut et al., 2019a; Simonsen, 2021; Wright, 2011). Specifically, the dominant integration framework of the host society helps explain whether bonding and bridging ties operate as substitutes or complements in generating belonging at the level of the political community.

We characterize this contextual variation using a plus-sum/zero-sum distinction. A *plus-sum* dynamic holds when both bonding and bridging ties can simultaneously support belonging at the level of the political community. This occurs in integration frameworks

that legitimize the maintenance of ethnic identity alongside participation in the broader society. Multiculturalism is the canonical example: by treating ethnic-community ties as compatible with — indeed constitutive of — national identity, multicultural frameworks make co-ethnic and cross-ethnic interactions additive rather than competing sources of belonging (Banting & Soroka, 2012; Citrin et al., 2012, 2014; Kymlicka, 1995; Taylor et al., 1994). A *zero-sum* dynamic, by contrast, holds when the integration framework creates tension between bonding and bridging. In contexts where integration is framed around convergence toward a shared linguistic and cultural identity (Bilodeau et al., 2022; Bouchard, 2011; Scott et al., 2024), bridging ties are the primary route to political belonging, while bonding ties remain orthogonal — neither helpful nor explicitly harmful, but politically illegible as evidence of integration into the host society. The zero-sum label is deliberately stronger than what we expect to observe; we use it to mark the theoretical contrast, not to predict that bonding ties damage belonging in such contexts.

This framework reframes the long-standing debate about whether bonding ties impede or support integration. The inconsistent findings produced by that debate may reflect real variation in the political contexts in which studies have been conducted, rather than measurement noise. Where the host society's integration framework legitimizes ethnic-community ties, bonding capital is integrative (Mc Kenzie, 2008; Sumaktoyo, 2021). Where the framework demands convergence, bonding capital is politically inert at the level where convergence is demanded, even if it remains valuable for emotional anchoring and community continuity. The framework also explains why bridging capital appears to have more uniform positive effects in the literature: bridging ties signal participation in the host society regardless of which integration framework operates, because they connect immigrants to majority-group members and broader institutions in ways that are politically legible across contexts.

Quebec and Canada provide an ideal paired comparison for testing this argument. Canada operationalizes multiculturalism at the federal level, formally legitimizing cultural plurality and treating the maintenance of ethnic identity as compatible with Canadian national identity (Banting & Soroka, 2012; Citrin et al., 2012; Kymlicka, 1995; Reeskens & Wright, 2013). Quebec operationalizes interculturalism at the provincial level. Interculturalism shares some features with multiculturalism in that it recognizes cultural diversity and protects minority rights, but it differs fundamentally in centering integration around a common public culture, organized around the French language and Québécois cultural norms (Bilodeau et al., 2022; Bouchard, 2011; Bouchard & Taylor, 2008; Scott et al., 2024). The result is a single immigrant population, drawn from a single survey, living simultaneously under two distinct integration frameworks. Immigrants in Quebec are Canadian citizens subject to federal multicultural policy, but they are also residents of a province whose integration regime is structured by linguistic and cultural convergence. This nested structure allows us to compare the meaning of social interactions across two integration frameworks while holding individual-level characteristics, immigration histories, and survey conditions constant.

The plus-sum/zero-sum framework also predicts the asymmetric costs of discrimina-

tion across political levels. A well-documented finding in the immigration literature complicates the recognition story: the more immigrants engage with the host society, the more discrimination they tend to report (Geurts et al., 2020; Lajevardi et al., 2020; Verkuyten, 2016). As immigrants become more educated, economically integrated, and socially connected, they also develop higher expectations of fair treatment and become more attuned to instances of exclusion (Oskooii, 2020; Schildkraut, 2005). The integration paradox suggests that discrimination is not simply a background condition independent of integration; it is partly a consequence of integration itself, particularly through cross-ethnic contact in majority-group spaces. The plus-sum/zero-sum framework specifies where these costs should be most acute. Under multiculturalism, where plurality is legitimized, differential treatment registers as a relatively smaller violation because plurality was never abandoned in the first place. Under interculturalism, where the framework demands convergence toward a common public culture, the gap between what integration demands and what immigrants actually experience in everyday interaction with majority members is larger, and discrimination registers as a more direct violation of the integration bargain. The 2019 passage of Bill 21, Quebec’s law restricting religious symbols in public service, generated intense public debate about the place of visible religious minorities in the province, and recent work has documented elevated patterns of exclusion among Muslim immigrants and visible minorities in Quebec specifically (Bilodeau et al., 2022; Djogbenou et al., 2025). We therefore expect the negative association between perceived discrimination and belonging to be most pronounced at the Quebec level.

A third level is neighborhood, which provides an apolitical baseline against which the politically structured Quebec and Canada effects can be evaluated. Locality belonging operates primarily through proximity, daily encounters, and the routines of everyday life, rather than through institutionalized integration frameworks (Wu et al., 2011; Yuval-Davis, 2006). While localities do have political institutions, they are not the primary sites where interculturalism or multiculturalism are operationalized as integration ideology. At the same time, neighborhoods are not neutral: substantial recent work shows that initial neighborhoods causally shape immigrants’ political integration through local networks and exposure (Andersson et al., 2022; Bratsberg et al., 2021). Comparing locality results to Quebec and Canada results lets us isolate which effects are driven by the political structure of integration and which simply reflect the everyday social texture of immigrant lives (Schildkraut et al., 2019a). The locality level is not a competing case but a reference point: it shows what belonging looks like when political-institutional context is held to a minimum.

2.4 Hypotheses

Combining the dimensional structure of belonging with the plus-sum/zero-sum distinction and the friendship/activities distinction, we derive predictions about how each form of social interaction translates into each dimension of belonging at the Quebec and Canada levels. The predictions follow from three linked claims developed above. First, cross-ethnic interactions primarily generate acceptance because they signal recognition by mem-

bers of the host society, while co-ethnic interactions primarily generate attachment because they provide emotional anchoring and cultural continuity within an immigrant community. Second, friendship reaches both dimensions because it involves sustained personal connection, while activities reach acceptance but not attachment because they are structured, public, and intermittent rather than personally intimate. Third, which level rewards which form of tie depends on the integration framework: Canadian multiculturalism legitimizes both bridging and bonding ties as routes to national belonging, while Quebec interculturalism makes only bridging ties politically legible as evidence of integration into the provincial community.

At the neighborhood level, which operates through everyday proximity rather than through an integration framework, we expect cross-ethnic friendship to operate similarly through personal recognition and familiarity, but make no framework-based predictions about co-ethnic interactions or activities. The neighborhood level serves as a baseline against which the politically structured Quebec and Canada effects can be evaluated.

2.4.1 Cross-Ethnic Interactions: Recognition as the Primary Channel

Cross-ethnic friendship signals personal recognition from members of the host society. This recognition signal is legible regardless of which integration framework operates, so we expect cross-ethnic friendship to be positively associated with acceptance at both the Quebec and Canada levels. On the contrary, whether cross-ethnic friendship also reaches attachment depends on the integration framework. In Quebec's interculturalist framework, where convergence toward a common public culture is the central integration demand, forming friendships across ethnic lines is itself part of what integration into the provincial community is taken to mean; cross-ethnic friendship should therefore also be positively associated with attachment to Quebec. In Canada's multicultural framework, where both bridging and bonding ties are legitimized as routes to national belonging, cross-ethnic friendship contributes to attachment alongside co-ethnic interactions rather than in competition with them; cross-ethnic friendship should therefore also be positively associated with attachment to Canada.

Cross-ethnic activities are a weaker, more structured form of contact, since they generate visibility within shared host-society spaces but lack the personal intimacy that produces internal identification. We therefore expect cross-ethnic activities to be positively associated with acceptance only where the integration framework explicitly rewards shared participation in a common public culture, which is Quebec.

Cross-Ethnic Friendship-Based Interaction

- **H1a:** Immigrants who spend more time with cross-ethnic friends report higher attachment at both the Quebec and Canada levels.

- **H1b:** Immigrants who spend more time with cross-ethnic friends report higher acceptance at both the Quebec and Canada levels.

Cross-Ethnic Activity-Based Interaction

- **H2a:** Immigrants who participate more in cross-ethnic sports and cultural activities will report no significant differences in emotional attachment at either the Quebec or Canada level.
- **H2b:** Immigrants who participate more in cross-ethnic sports and cultural activities report higher acceptance at the Quebec level, but not at the Canada level.

2.4.2 Co-Ethnic Interactions: Anchoring Where the Framework Allows

Co-ethnic friendship provides cultural continuity and emotional anchoring within the immigrant community. Whether this anchoring translates into attachment to the political community depends on the integration framework. Under Canadian multiculturalism, which explicitly legitimizes ethnic-community interactions as compatible with national identification, co-ethnic friendship should support attachment to Canada. Under Quebec's interculturalism, which centers belonging on convergence toward a common public culture, co-ethnic friendship remains politically orthogonal to provincial belonging, neither helpful nor harmful, but not legible as evidence of integration into the Quebec community. We predict no meaningful relationship between co-ethnic friendship and attachment to Quebec, rather than a negative one. Co-ethnic friendship would not be meaningfully related to acceptance at either level, because bonding ties provide internal anchoring rather than external recognition by the broader community.

Co-ethnic activities are the weakest form of bonding contact. They lack both the personal intimacy of friendship and the cross-group recognition of bridging ties. We therefore expect co-ethnic activities to have no meaningful relationship with either dimension of belonging at either political level.

Co-Ethnic Friendship-Based Interaction

- **H3a:** Immigrants with more co-ethnic friendships will report no significant differences in perceived acceptance at either the Quebec or Canada level.
- **H3b:** Immigrants with more co-ethnic friendships will report higher levels of emotional attachment at the Canada level, but no significant difference at the Quebec level.

Co-Ethnic Activity-Based Interaction

- **H4:** Immigrants who participate more in co-ethnic sports and cultural activities do not report meaningfully different attachment or acceptance at either the Quebec or Canada level.

2.4.3 Discrimination and the Asymmetric Costs of Engagement

The plus-sum/zero-sum framework also predicts the structure of discrimination's costs. Where the integration framework demands convergence, the gap between integration expectations and the actual experience of recognition is largest, and discrimination registers as a more direct violation of the integration bargain. We therefore expect discrimination's negative association with belonging to be most pronounced at the Quebec level, where Quebec's interculturalist framework places more demanding expectations on immigrants than Canada's multicultural framework. The neighborhood level, which operates through everyday proximity rather than through an integration framework, should fall between the two: discrimination is costly at any level because it directly contradicts the perception of being valued, but its costs should be most concentrated where the political framework's demands are highest.

- **H5:** The negative association between perceived discrimination and belonging is strongest at the Quebec level, compared to belonging at the Canada and neighborhood levels.

3 Research Design

3.1 Data

This paper draws on original survey data collected as part of a research project on immigrant participation in Quebec, directed by the second author and funded by the Fonds de recherche du Québec–Société et culture (FRQSC) and the Quebec Ministry of Immigration, Francization, and Integration (MIFI).¹ The survey was administered between April and July 2019. The full project surveyed 2,065 first-generation immigrants and a comparison sample of 3,041 majority-group respondents across 29 Quebec localities. Of the 2,065 first-generation immigrants, 1,795 have complete data on all variables used in the analysis. To keep coefficients comparable across outcomes and specifications, we estimate all models on this common analytic sample rather than letting *N* vary by model. This paper uses the immigrant sample, which was stratified by locality. The 29 localities were selected to

¹Project 2018-PM-211357, "La participation des personnes immigrantes au Québec: Mieux comprendre l'effet structurant du contexte dans 29 localités."

capture the full range of residential contexts in which immigrants live in Quebec. Because the immigrant population is heavily concentrated in the Greater Montreal area, the local-city sample is anchored in Montreal: nineteen are boroughs (*arrondissements*) of the City of Montreal, two are West Island municipalities, six are South Shore, Laval, or off-island municipalities in the Montreal region, and four are localities outside the Montreal region (Gatineau, Sherbrooke, Terrebonne, and Quebec City). This design captures variation in immigrant residential context, including density of co-ethnic community, neighborhood-level diversity, and the openness of the majority population, while concentrating sampling where immigrants actually live.

The survey was administered in mixed mode (web and telephone) to maximize reach across age, socioeconomic status, and digital access. The 2019 fieldwork also coincides with the passage of Bill 21, Quebec’s law restricting religious symbols in public service, which was a political moment that makes the data particularly well-suited to examining how immigrant belonging is shaped by Quebec’s distinctive integration framework.

3.2 Variables

3.2.1 Explanatory Variables: Social Interactions²

1. **Cross-Ethnic Interaction (0–1):** We use two indicators of interaction with individuals from different backgrounds.
 - *Cross-ethnic friendships:* spending time with friends in Quebec who are of a different ethnic, cultural, or national origin. This indicator captures more personal and self-selected social relationships characterized by trust and repeated interaction.
 - *Cross-ethnic sports and cultural activities:* participation in sports or cultural activities in Quebec with individuals from different ethnic, cultural, or national backgrounds. This indicator reflects more structured and cooperative forms of interaction that are often shaped by opportunity and involve less individual control over the composition of participants.
2. **Co-Ethnic Interaction (0–1):** We use two indicators of interaction with individuals from the same backgrounds.
 - *Co-ethnic friendships:* spending time with friends in Quebec who share the respondent’s ethnic, cultural, or national origin.

²The survey includes items on political activities with co-ethnic and cross-ethnic contacts, but these items are not included in the interaction measures used in our study. Political participation differs conceptually from everyday social interaction, as it is more organized, selective, and often contingent on prior political inclusion and legal status. Because the focus of this paper is on routine, informal social interaction, the interaction measures are constructed using non-political activities — sports, cultural activities, and friendship — that capture naturalistic contact in everyday life. In addition, there is a possibility of endogeneity between political activities and belonging, which gave us additional reason not to include the indicator.

- *Co-ethnic sports and cultural activities*: participation in sports or cultural activities in Quebec with individuals of the same ethnic, cultural, or national origin.

3.2.2 Outcome Variables: Sense of Belonging

We used two indicators to measure a sense of belonging: feelings of attachment and feelings of acceptance.

1. **Feelings of attachment**: emotional attachment to Neighborhood/Quebec/Canada
 - 0 (completely disagree) – 1 (completely agree)
2. **Feelings of acceptance**: feelings of acceptance by Neighborhood/Quebec/Canada
 - 0 (completely disagree) – 1 (completely agree)

3.2.3 Confounding Variables

1. English proficiency (0–1): On a scale from 0 to 10, where 10 means you have perfect command of the language and 0 means you do not master the language at all, please rate your level of proficiency in English.
2. French proficiency (0–1): On a scale from 0 to 10, where 10 means you have perfect command of the language and 0 means you do not master the language at all, please rate your level of proficiency in French.
3. Age
4. Gender (0 = Female, 1 = Male)
5. Education: recoded as a binary variable (0 = below university, 1 = university degree or higher), reflecting the positive selection of immigrants into higher education observed in our sample, where 60.5% hold a university degree or higher.
6. Recent immigration: whether they immigrated to Canada in the last 10 years (recent = 1; otherwise recent = 0).
7. Muslim (0 = non-Muslim, 1 = Muslim)
8. Racialized minorities (0 = White, 1 = non-White)
9. Perceived discrimination (0 = never, 3 = frequent)

3.3 Methods

We estimate within-locality fixed-effects regression models to assess how cross-ethnic and co-ethnic social interactions are associated with immigrants' sense of belonging. The fixed-effects specification accounts for all time-invariant features of localities, including their socioeconomic composition, the density of immigrant communities, and the political-institutional environment in which respondents live. This approach allows us to estimate within-locality associations while accounting for shared contextual factors. Standard errors are clustered at the locality level to account for potential correlation in unobserved factors among respondents living in the same locality. The baseline specification is as follows:

$$Y_{ij} = \beta_1 \text{CrossEthnic}_{ij} + \beta_2 \text{CoEthnic}_{ij} + X_{ij}\gamma + \alpha_j + \varepsilon_{ij} \quad (1)$$

where Y_{ij} denotes the belonging outcome of individual i living in locality j . CrossEthnic_{ij} and CoEthnic_{ij} measure cross-ethnic and co-ethnic social interaction, respectively. X_{ij} is a vector of individual-level confounders. α_j represents locality fixed effects for the 29 localities, and ε_{ij} is an error term.

We estimate this specification separately for each of the three belonging outcomes: locality, Quebec, and Canada. Modeling these outcomes separately rather than stacking them lets us compare coefficients across political levels, which is central to the plus-sum/zero-sum framework developed in our theory. For each outcome, we report three nested specifications. The basic model includes only the four social interaction indicators. The demographic model adds individual-level controls (age, gender, education, recent immigration, racialized minority status, Muslim identity, and survey mode). The full model further adds French and English proficiency and perceived discrimination. The nested structure allows us to assess whether the effects of social interaction persist net of demographic composition and theoretically relevant covariates, and to evaluate the attenuation of coefficients after adding discrimination on the cross-ethnic interaction coefficients.

To test the moderating role of settlement stage, we estimate interaction models that include all four social interaction measures, a recent immigrant indicator, and the interactions between them, retaining the full set of controls and locality fixed effects. We report predicted belonging at low and high levels of cross-ethnic friendship separately for recent and established immigrants.

We conducted standard diagnostics for our specification. Variance inflation factors for all predictors are below 2, indicating no multicollinearity concerns among the social interaction indicators, religious identity variables, racialized minority status, and perceived discrimination. Pairwise correlations among the religious, racial, and discrimination variables range from 0.11 to 0.32, confirming that they capture distinct constructs. As an empirical extension, we further decompose belonging into its two underlying dimensions, feelings of attachment and feelings of acceptance, and re-estimate the main models with each dimension as a separate outcome. This decomposition provides additional insight

into the mechanism through which social interaction operates and how perceived discrimination relates to different facets of belonging.

4 Empirical Results

4.1 Descriptive Statistics

Table 1 reports descriptive statistics for the 1,795 first-generation immigrants in our analytic sample. The sample is diverse along key demographic dimensions: 57% are racialized minorities, 19% are Muslim, 19% arrived in the past ten years, and 61% hold a university degree or higher. Belonging is generally high across all three political levels, with mean values between 0.78 and 0.84 on a 0–1 scale. Belonging to Canada is on average the highest and least dispersed (mean 0.84, SD 0.16), while belonging to Quebec shows the greatest variation (mean 0.78, SD 0.20). This pattern suggests that belonging to Quebec is more conditional on individual characteristics and experiences than belonging to Canada, foreshadowing the differential role that political-institutional context plays in our analysis. Cross-ethnic and co-ethnic friendships occur at broadly comparable frequencies (means 0.65 and 0.64), while activity-based interactions are less frequent and more skewed toward cross-ethnic than co-ethnic settings (means 0.47 and 0.38). Nearly half of respondents (48%) report having experienced discrimination, a baseline that will be relevant when we examine the integration paradox in later analyses.

Cell entries in Table 1 are means with standard deviations in parentheses for continuous variables and percentages for binary variables. Belonging measures are rescaled to 0–1. Social interaction variables are frequencies of contact through friendship and sports/cultural activities, measured on a four-point scale (never, a few times a year, a few times a month, weekly) and rescaled to 0–1. Perceived discrimination is dichotomized in this table (1 if respondent reports any discrimination, 0 if never); in the regression analyses it is included as a four-category measure (0 = never, 1 = rarely, 2 = occasionally, 3 = frequently).

To provide an initial overview of the distribution of belonging, Figure 1 presents density plots of immigrants' reported feelings of acceptance and attachment at three levels: the local community, the provincial context (Quebec), and the national level (Canada). Across all six indicators, responses are heavily skewed toward higher values, indicating that most respondents report strong feelings of both acceptance and attachment. Three patterns stand out. First, acceptance and attachment to Canada are concentrated at the top end of the scale, indicating a consistently high sense of national belonging that likely reflects Canada's inclusive, multicultural framework. Second, feelings of belonging to Quebec are more varied and distributed across the mid-to-upper range, suggesting a less uniform and more conditional sense of provincial belonging. Third, belonging at the local level is also high, particularly for perceived acceptance, which shows a sharp peak near the top of the scale. This last pattern supports the idea that local communities serve as

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics for the Analysis Sample

Variable	Mean (SD) or %
<i>Sample size</i>	
N	1,795
<i>Belonging outcomes (0–1 scale)</i>	
Belonging (Locality)	0.79 (0.18)
Attachment (Locality)	0.75 (0.23)
Acceptance (Locality)	0.84 (0.19)
Belonging (Quebec)	0.78 (0.20)
Attachment (Quebec)	0.80 (0.22)
Acceptance (Quebec)	0.76 (0.23)
Belonging (Canada)	0.84 (0.16)
Attachment (Canada)	0.84 (0.18)
Acceptance (Canada)	0.84 (0.18)
<i>Social interaction (0–1 scale)</i>	
Cross-ethnic friendship	0.65 (0.31)
Co-ethnic friendship	0.64 (0.32)
Cross-ethnic activities	0.47 (0.35)
Co-ethnic activities	0.38 (0.34)
<i>Language proficiency (0–1 scale)</i>	
French proficiency	0.85 (0.22)
English proficiency	0.69 (0.27)
<i>Demographics</i>	
Age (years)	51.8 (16.4)
Male (%)	42.9
University degree or higher (%)	60.6
Recent immigrant: arrived ≤ 10 years ago (%)	18.8
<i>Identity and experience</i>	
Racialized minority (%)	56.7
Muslim (%)	18.9
Reported any discrimination (%)	47.6
<i>Survey mode</i>	
Web (%)	45.0

relational spaces where immigrants form meaningful connections relatively independent of political or institutional frameworks.

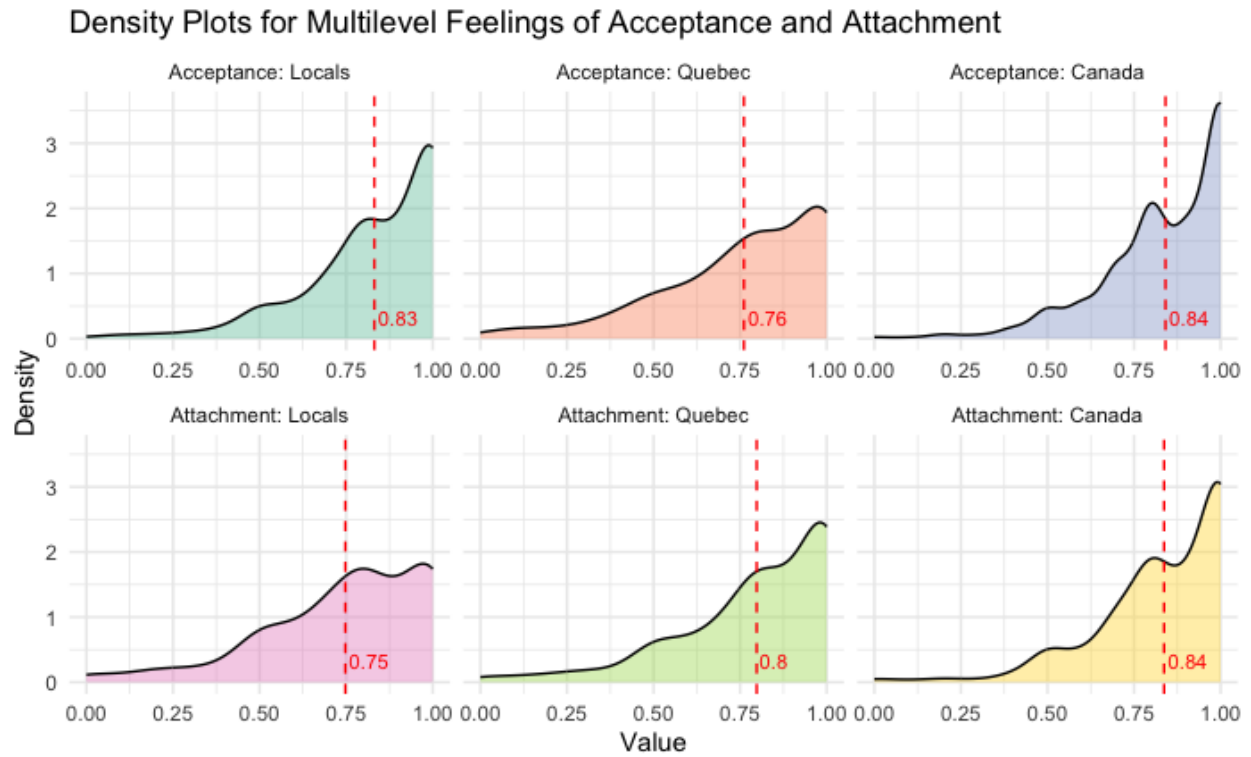
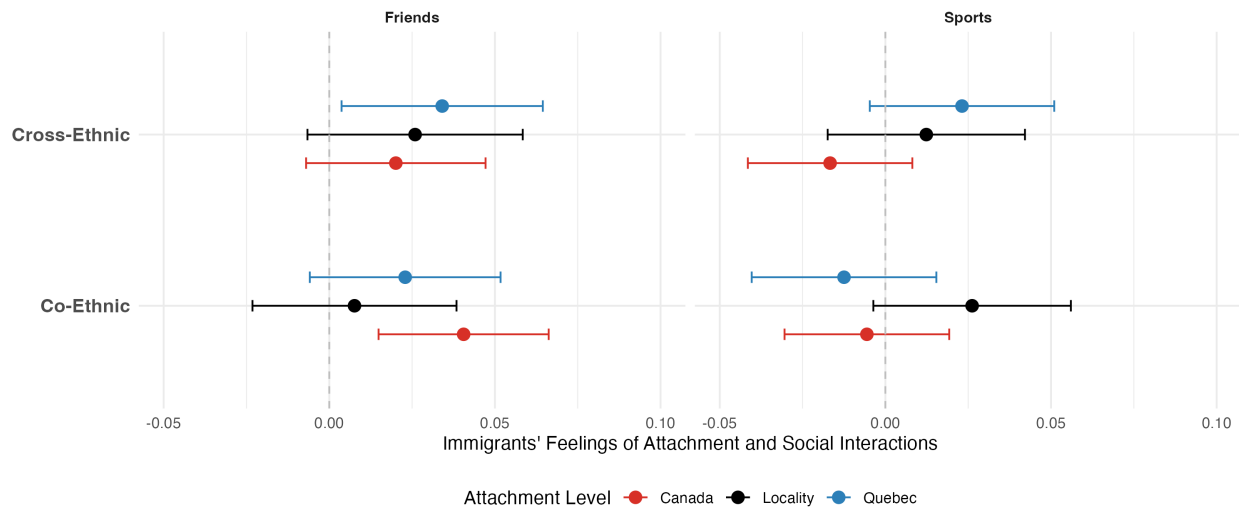


Figure 1: Density Plots for Multi-Level Feelings of Acceptance and Attachment



Error bars show 90% confidence intervals (approximately $p < 0.1$).

Figure 2: Friendship-Based Interactions on Attachment Across Three Levels (90% CI)

4.2 Main Analysis

4.2.1 Feelings of Attachment

Table 2 presents fixed-effects estimates for attachment at the neighborhood, Quebec, and Canada levels, across three model specifications: a basic model with the four social-interaction measures, a demographic model adding individual-level covariates, and a full model further including French and English proficiency and perceived discrimination.

Friendship-Based Interactions and Attachment The results in Figure 2 and Table 2 reveal two patterns. First, immigrants who spend more time with cross-ethnic friends tend to feel more attached to Quebec, though this effect reaches only marginal significance in the full specification ($\beta = 0.034, p < 0.1$). The coefficient is positive and stable across all three model specifications for Quebec, while the Canada coefficient is positive in the basic and demographic models but drops to non-significant once we control for discrimination and language proficiency. This partially supports H1a, which predicted positive associations at both levels. The pattern is consistent with the theoretical role of cross-ethnic friendship in Quebec’s intercultural framework, which emphasizes convergence around a shared linguistic and civic project: in this context, bridging ties function as a form of incorporation into the Quebec community itself, with immigrants who form friendships across ethnic lines not just being sociable but participating in the provincial identity project.

Second, immigrants who spend more time with co-ethnic friends tend to feel more attached to Canada ($\beta = 0.041, p < 0.01$), but this pattern does not appear at the neighborhood or Quebec levels. This supports H3b. Co-ethnic friendship is positively associated with attachment to Canada in a way that is consistent with Canadian multiculturalism, which legitimizes the maintenance of ethnic-community ties as compatible with, and supportive of, national identification (Banting & Soroka, 2012; Bilodeau et al., 2020). Under a framework that does not require cultural convergence, bonding ties provide the cultural continuity and emotional anchor that complement, rather than compete with, attachment to the nation.

Activity-Based Interaction and Attachment In contrast to friendship, participation in sports and cultural activities can hardly explain attachment at any level. Immigrants who engage in more cross-ethnic activities do not report meaningfully different attachment at the neighborhood, Quebec, or Canada level, supporting H2a. The same holds for co-ethnic activities, consistent with the attachment portion of H4. The implication is that activity-based contact, which is more structured, public, and intermittent than friendship, can shift perceptions of recognition (which we examine in the next section) without reaching the deeper internal identification that attachment captures. Internal identification appears to require sustained, personal forms of connection rather than episodic shared participation.

Table 2: Fixed-Effects Estimates of Social Interaction and Attachment

	Neighborhood			Quebec			Canada		
	Basic	Demo	Full	Basic	Demo	Full	Basic	Demo	Full
Cross-Ethnic Friends	0.057*** (0.021)	0.029 (0.020)	0.026 (0.020)	0.061*** (0.020)	0.037** (0.019)	0.034* (0.018)	0.038** (0.017)	0.034** (0.016)	0.020 (0.016)
Co-Ethnic Friends	-0.019 (0.020)	0.002 (0.019)	0.008 (0.019)	-0.008 (0.019)	0.011 (0.018)	0.023 (0.018)	0.036** (0.016)	0.037** (0.016)	0.041*** (0.016)
Cross-Ethnic Activities	-0.004 (0.019)	0.015 (0.018)	0.012 (0.018)	0.018 (0.018)	0.036** (0.017)	0.023 (0.017)	-0.029* (0.015)	-0.014 (0.015)	-0.017 (0.015)
Co-Ethnic Activities	-0.006 (0.019)	0.021 (0.018)	0.026 (0.018)	-0.042** (0.018)	-0.022 (0.018)	-0.012 (0.017)	-0.020 (0.016)	-0.013 (0.015)	-0.006 (0.015)
French Proficiency			0.033 (0.024)			0.155*** (0.022)			0.054*** (0.020)
English Proficiency			-0.010 (0.021)			-0.059*** (0.019)			0.064*** (0.017)
Male		-0.062*** (0.010)	-0.063*** (0.010)		-0.029*** (0.010)	-0.027*** (0.010)		-0.028*** (0.009)	-0.030*** (0.009)
Education		-0.004 (0.003)	-0.003 (0.003)		-0.004 (0.003)	-0.002 (0.003)		-0.009*** (0.002)	-0.012*** (0.002)
Age		0.003*** (0.000)	0.003*** (0.000)		0.003*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.000)		0.002*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.000)
Recent Immigrant		-0.041*** (0.015)	-0.039*** (0.015)		-0.011 (0.014)	-0.005 (0.014)		0.002 (0.012)	0.012 (0.012)
Racialized Minority		0.005 (0.011)	0.018 (0.012)		-0.008 (0.011)	0.018* (0.011)		0.037*** (0.009)	0.048*** (0.010)
Muslim Identity		0.048*** (0.014)	0.045*** (0.014)		0.003 (0.013)	-0.010 (0.013)		0.059*** (0.012)	0.061*** (0.012)
Perceived Discrimination			-0.051*** (0.011)			-0.083*** (0.010)			-0.031*** (0.009)
Web Mode		-0.086*** (0.012)	-0.080*** (0.012)		-0.070*** (0.011)	-0.066*** (0.011)		-0.040*** (0.010)	-0.039*** (0.010)
N	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795
R ²	0.005	0.139	0.151	0.012	0.105	0.171	0.010	0.075	0.091
Adj. R ²	-0.013	0.120	0.131	-0.006	0.085	0.151	-0.008	0.054	0.070

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Standard errors in parentheses.

4.2.2 Feelings of Acceptance

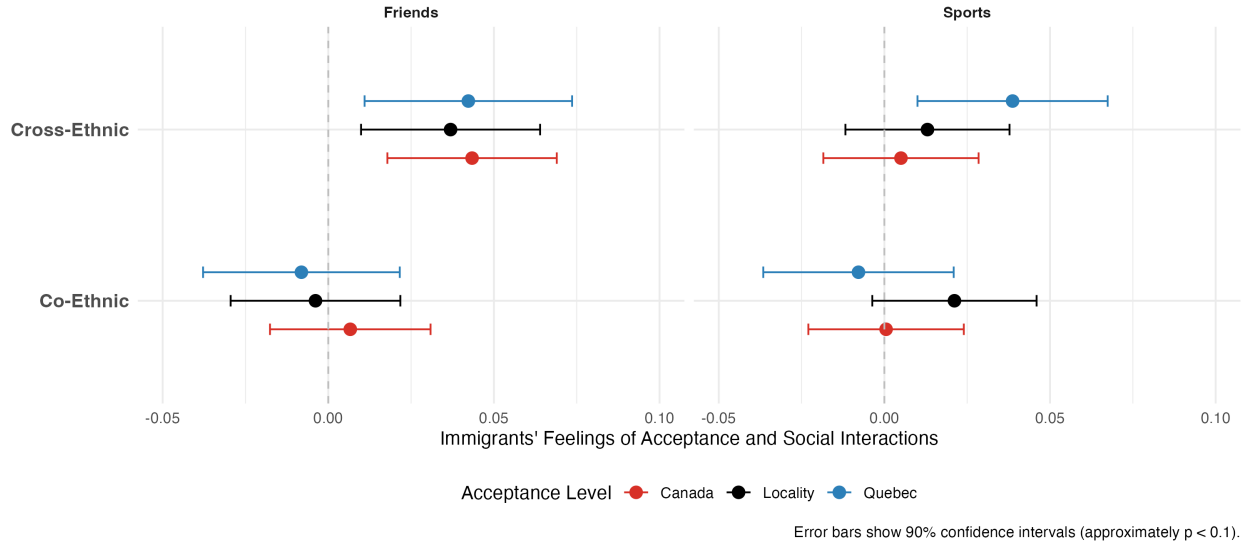


Figure 3: Friendship-Based Interactions on Acceptance Across Three Levels (90% CI)

We now turn to acceptance, the dimension of belonging that captures immigrants' perception of being recognized as part of the community. Where attachment is internal identification, acceptance is the sense that one is seen and valued by others. Table 3 presents fixed-effects estimates for acceptance at the neighborhood, Quebec, and Canada levels, using the same three model specifications as before. The pattern that emerges is broader than for attachment: everyday social interactions are associated with acceptance across multiple levels, and the integration frameworks of Quebec and Canada show their distinctive signatures more clearly here.

Friendship-Based Interaction and Acceptance Immigrants who spend more time with cross-ethnic friends feel more accepted at all three levels (Neighborhood $\beta = 0.037$, $p < 0.05$; Quebec $\beta = 0.042$, $p < 0.05$; Canada $\beta = 0.043$, $p < 0.01$). This is the most consistent finding in the paper and fully supports H1b. Cross-ethnic friendship raises perceived acceptance whether immigrants are reporting on their neighborhood, the province, or the country, and the effect holds net of language proficiency, demographic characteristics, and perceived discrimination. Co-ethnic friendship, by contrast, shows no meaningful association with acceptance at any level once controls are introduced, supporting H3a. Immigrants with more bonding ties show no systematic difference in their sense of being accepted by the broader community, which is consistent with the theoretical expectation that bonding ties provide internal anchoring rather than external recognition.

Activity-Based Interaction and Acceptance Immigrants who engage in more cross-ethnic activities feel more accepted at the Quebec level ($\beta = 0.039$, $p < 0.05$), but not at the neighborhood or Canada levels. This supports H2b. Co-ethnic activities show no meaningful

association with acceptance at any level once covariates are introduced, consistent with the acceptance portion of H4.

The Quebec-specific pattern for cross-ethnic activities is theoretically informative. Activities are a more structured and public form of contact than friendship, and they are closer to the kind of cooperative participation that Quebec’s intercultural framework explicitly calls for as evidence of integration. Cross-ethnic activities map onto exactly this demand, while the absence of an analogous effect at the Canadian level reinforces the interpretation: multicultural Canada welcomes both bridging and bonding ties without specifically conditioning acceptance on shared cooperative activity.

4.2.3 Confounders

Several confounding variables also show theoretically consistent patterns. French proficiency is positively associated with both attachment and acceptance at the Quebec and Canada levels, reflecting the central role of linguistic competence in facilitating social integration. English proficiency, by contrast, is positively associated with belonging to Canada but negatively associated with belonging to Quebec. This divergence parallels the cross-ethnic and co-ethnic patterns we documented for social interaction. While English aligns with participation in Canada’s broader multicultural and civic space, it does not have the same meaning in Quebec’s linguistically bounded context. French proficiency operates as a plus-sum resource that supports belonging at both levels, while English proficiency operates as a zero-sum resource that supports national belonging but not provincial belonging.

The pattern for recent immigrants is also theoretically informative. Recent immigrants, those who arrived in Canada within the past ten years, report lower attachment ($\beta = -0.039, p < 0.01$) and lower acceptance ($\beta = -0.044, p < 0.01$) at the neighborhood level, but show no meaningful difference at the Quebec or Canada levels. This level-specific penalty makes sense: neighborhood belonging is built through repeated local interactions, repeated routines, and accumulated familiarity, none of which recent arrivals have had time to develop. Belonging at the Quebec and Canada levels, by contrast, is shaped by political messaging, institutional narratives, and symbolic frameworks of inclusion that do not require time-accumulated local experience. The political levels announce who belongs; the neighborhood level requires immigrants to learn it.

4.2.4 Comparing Attachment and Acceptance

When we compare the results across the two dimensions, three patterns are worth flagging. First, immigrants who report more discrimination show lower acceptance much more than they show lower attachment. The magnitude of the discrimination coefficient is consistently larger for acceptance than for attachment at every level we examine. We return to the level-specific gradient of discrimination’s costs in Section 4.3. Second, activ-

Table 3: Fixed-Effects Estimates of Social Interaction and Feelings of Acceptance

	Neighborhood			Quebec			Canada		
	Basic	Demo	Full	Basic	Demo	Full	Basic	Demo	Full
Cross-Ethnic Friends	0.083*** (0.017)	0.055*** (0.017)	0.037** (0.016)	0.084*** (0.021)	0.056*** (0.020)	0.042** (0.019)	0.079*** (0.016)	0.065*** (0.016)	0.043*** (0.016)
Co-Ethnic Friends	-0.031* (0.017)	-0.013 (0.016)	-0.004 (0.016)	-0.048** (0.020)	-0.027 (0.019)	-0.008 (0.018)	-0.012 (0.015)	-0.002 (0.015)	0.007 (0.015)
Cross-Ethnic Activities	0.009 (0.016)	0.019 (0.016)	0.013 (0.015)	0.031 (0.019)	0.052*** (0.019)	0.039** (0.017)	-0.004 (0.015)	0.009 (0.015)	0.005 (0.014)
Co-Ethnic Activities	-0.012 (0.016)	0.008 (0.016)	0.021 (0.015)	-0.048** (0.020)	-0.027 (0.019)	-0.008 (0.017)	-0.022 (0.015)	-0.014 (0.015)	0.001 (0.014)
French Proficiency			0.098*** (0.020)			0.168*** (0.023)			0.079*** (0.019)
English Proficiency			0.057*** (0.017)			-0.025 (0.020)			0.081*** (0.016)
Male		-0.028*** (0.009)	-0.031*** (0.009)		-0.016 (0.011)	-0.017* (0.010)		-0.018** (0.008)	-0.022*** (0.008)
Education		-0.003 (0.002)	-0.005* (0.002)		-0.008*** (0.003)	-0.007** (0.003)		-0.009*** (0.002)	-0.011*** (0.002)
Age		0.001*** (0.000)	0.001*** (0.000)		0.002*** (0.000)	0.001*** (0.000)		0.001*** (0.000)	0.001*** (0.000)
Recent Immigrant		-0.058*** (0.012)	-0.044*** (0.012)		-0.012 (0.015)	0.000 (0.014)		-0.015 (0.012)	0.000 (0.012)
Racialized Minority		-0.032*** (0.010)	-0.006 (0.010)		-0.045*** (0.012)	0.000 (0.011)		-0.024** (0.009)	0.002 (0.009)
Muslim Identity		0.026** (0.012)	0.024** (0.012)		-0.063*** (0.014)	-0.075*** (0.013)		0.040*** (0.011)	0.041*** (0.011)
Perceived Discrimination			-0.085*** (0.009)			-0.156*** (0.010)			-0.085*** (0.009)
Web Mode		-0.060*** (0.010)	-0.053*** (0.010)		-0.054*** (0.012)	-0.040*** (0.011)		-0.023** (0.010)	-0.015 (0.009)
N	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795
R ²	0.019	0.104	0.164	0.022	0.115	0.244	0.018	0.057	0.127
Adj. R ²	0.001	0.084	0.144	0.004	0.095	0.225	0.000	0.036	0.106

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Standard errors in parentheses.

ities are associated with acceptance but not attachment. Cross-ethnic activities raise acceptance at the Quebec level but do not move attachment at any level. Friendship, by contrast, moves both dimensions, though with different level-specific patterns. Third, the level-specific patterns form a clean test of the plus-sum/zero-sum framework. At the Canadian national level, cross-ethnic friendship raises acceptance while co-ethnic friendship raises attachment: both types of tie contribute to belonging, each through a distinct dimension. At the Quebec provincial level, only cross-ethnic interactions produce meaningful associations — cross-ethnic friendship raises acceptance and marginally attachment, cross-ethnic activities raise acceptance — while co-ethnic interactions remain inert across both dimensions. At the neighborhood level, only cross-ethnic friendship matters.

4.3 The Asymmetric Costs of Discrimination

The findings in the previous section establish that integration frameworks structure which interactions are associated with which dimensions of belonging at which levels. We now turn to the costs side of the same political-context argument. H5 predicts that the negative association between perceived discrimination and belonging is most pronounced at the Quebec level, where the convergence-oriented integration framework places more demanding expectations on immigrants than Canada’s multicultural framework.

The evidence supports H5 across both dimensions of belonging. For acceptance, the discrimination coefficient is -0.156 at the Quebec level (Table 3), compared to -0.085 at the neighborhood level and -0.085 at the Canada level. For attachment, the corresponding coefficients are -0.083 at Quebec (Table 2), -0.051 at the neighborhood, and -0.031 at Canada. The Quebec coefficient is roughly twice the magnitude of the Canada coefficient for both dimensions, though we note that the comparison is across separately estimated models rather than a formal interaction test. The gradient is consistent with H5: discrimination is associated with the largest reduction in belonging precisely where integration expectations are most demanding.

A related pattern appears for Muslim identity. Muslim immigrants report higher acceptance and attachment at the Canada level (acceptance $\beta = 0.041$, $p < 0.01$; attachment $\beta = 0.061$, $p < 0.01$) and at the neighborhood level, but markedly lower acceptance at the Quebec level ($\beta = -0.075$, $p < 0.01$). The contrast is consistent with the plus-sum/zero-sum framework: where the host society’s framework legitimizes religious and cultural diversity, as in Canada’s multicultural model, Muslim identity is associated with higher belonging. Where the framework centers on convergence toward a common public culture, as in Quebec’s interculturalist model, visible religious identity is associated with lower belonging. The broader political debates around Bill 21, Quebec’s law restricting religious symbols in public service passed in the same year as our survey, illustrate the contested place of visible religious minorities in the province (Bilodeau et al., 2022; Djogbenou et al., 2025).

The discrimination findings tie back directly to the recognition findings of the previous

section. Cross-ethnic friendship raises acceptance most clearly at the Quebec level, where the intercultural framework rewards visible participation in a common public culture — but the same Quebec context produces the largest discrimination-related deficits when that recognition is denied. This is the political-behavior signature of the plus-sum/zero-sum framework: where the integration framework asks more of immigrants, both the returns to engagement and the costs of exclusion are correspondingly larger.

5 Conclusion

In this paper, we examined how different forms of social interactions are associated with immigrant belonging across political contexts. Drawing on original survey data from immigrants in Quebec, we showed that the meaning of social interactions depends on the integration framework of the host society. We find that (1) cross-ethnic friendship raises feelings of acceptance at all three levels — neighborhood, Quebec, and Canada — as the most consistent finding in the paper; (2) co-ethnic friendship raises feelings of attachment to Canada but not to Quebec, consistent with Canada’s multicultural framework and Quebec’s interculturalist framework; (3) cross-ethnic activities raise acceptance at the Quebec level but not at the Canada level, consistent with Quebec’s interculturalist demand for shared cooperative participation in a common public culture; and (4) the negative association between perceived discrimination and belonging is most pronounced at the Quebec level. These patterns are consistent with the broader argument that engagement with the host society produces both larger returns and larger costs where integration expectations are most demanding.

This paper has three contributions. The first concerns the long-running debate over whether bonding and bridging ties operate as complements or competitors in shaping immigrant integration. We argue that the plus-sum/zero-sum framework offers a way to organize this variation: where the integration framework legitimizes ethnic-community ties, as in Canadian multiculturalism, bonding capital is integrative. Where the framework demands convergence, as in Quebec interculturalism, bonding capital is politically orthogonal to belonging at the level where convergence is demanded. The same form of tie can therefore have different consequences in different political contexts.

The second contribution concerns the role of subnational political contexts in shaping immigrant integration. Most existing research treats the nation-state as the relevant integration unit. Yet many immigrants live in subnational communities with their own integration regimes, particularly in minority-nation contexts. Our case design exploits this layered political reality: the same immigrant population is simultaneously subject to Canada’s multicultural framework and Quebec’s interculturalist framework. The findings demonstrate that these two frameworks produce different consequences for the same social interactions, suggesting that minority-nation contexts deserve more attention in the comparative study of immigrant integration.

The third contribution concerns the costs that accompany the integrative benefits of cross-ethnic engagement. Engagement with the host society is not uniformly beneficial. Our findings show that the contexts where cross-ethnic friendship is most consequential for belonging are also the contexts where discrimination is most costly. Immigrants in Quebec experience the largest discrimination-associated reduction in belonging, and the convergence-oriented integration framework that makes recognition through engagement most consequential is also the framework where exclusion is most costly. These asymmetric consequences are consistent with a broader concern in the integration literature: that the rewards and burdens of integration are unevenly distributed across immigrants and political contexts.

References

- Allport, G. W. (1979). *The nature of prejudice* (Unabridged, 25th anniversary ed). Addison-Wesley Pub. Co.
- Alrababa'h, A., Marble, W., Mousa, S., & Siegel, A. A. (2019). Can Exposure to Celebrities Reduce Prejudice? The Effect of Mohamed Salah on Islamophobic Behaviors and Attitudes. *Immigration Policy Lab*. <https://doi.org/10.31235/osf.io/eq8ca>
- Amit, K., & Bar-Lev, S. (2015). Immigrants' Sense of Belonging to the Host Country: The Role of Life Satisfaction, Language Proficiency, and Religious Motives. *Social Indicators Research*, 124(3), 947–961. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11205-014-0823-3>
- Andersson, H., Lajevardi, N., Lindgren, K.-O., & Oskarsson, S. (2022). Effects of Settlement into Ethnic Enclaves on Immigrant Voter Turnout. *The Journal of Politics*, 84(1), 578–584. <https://doi.org/10.1086/715160>
- Banting, K., & Soroka, S. (2012). Minority nationalism and immigrant integration in Canada. *Nations and Nationalism*, 18(1), 156–176. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1469-8129.2011.00535.x>
- Bilodeau, A., White, S., Turgeon, L., & Henderson, A. (2022). Ethnic minority belonging in a multilevel political community: The role of exclusionary experiences and welcoming provincial contexts in Canada. *Territory, Politics, Governance*, 1–20. <https://doi.org/10.1080/21622671.2022.2080758>
- Bilodeau, A., White, S. E., Turgeon, L., & Henderson, A. (2020). Feeling Attached and Feeling Accepted: Implications for Political Inclusion among Visible Minority Immigrants in Canada. *International Migration*, 58(2), 272–288. <https://doi.org/10.1111/imig.12657>
- Bouchard, G. (2011). What is interculturalism? *McGill Law Journal*, 56(2), 435–468.
- Bouchard, G., & Taylor, C. (2008). *Building the future: A time for reconciliation* (tech. rep.). Consultation Commission on Accommodation Practices Related to Cultural Differences, Government of Quebec. Québec.
- Bratsberg, B., Ferwerda, J., Finseraas, H., & Kotsadam, A. (2021). How Settlement Locations and Local Networks Influence Immigrant Political Integration. *American Journal of Political Science*, 65(3), 551–565. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12532>

- Choi, D. D., Sambanis, N., & Poertner, M. (2022). Native bias: Overcoming discrimination against immigrants.
- Citrin, J., Johnston, R., & Wright, M. (2012). Do Patriotism and Multiculturalism Collide? Competing Perspectives from Canada and the United States. *Canadian Journal of Political Science*, 45(3), 531–552. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0008423912000704>
- Citrin, J., Levy, M., & Wright, M. (2014). Multicultural policy and political support in european democracies. *Comparative Political Studies*, 47(11), 1531–1557.
- Djogbenou, R., Adjiwanou, V., & Lardoux, S. (2025). Immigrants' sense of belonging in Quebec: The role of perceived discrimination and participation in associations and sports. *International Journal of Intercultural Relations*, 108, 102209. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijintrel.2025.102209>
- Ferwerda, J., Finseraas, H., & Bergh, J. (2020). Voting Rights and Immigrant Incorporation: Evidence from Norway. *British Journal of Political Science*, 50(2), 713–730. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0007123417000643>
- Fingerman, K. L. (2009). Consequential Strangers and Peripheral Ties: The Importance of Unimportant Relationships. *Journal of Family Theory & Review*, 1(2), 69–86. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1756-2589.2009.00010.x>
- Fuchs, L. M., Jacobsen, J., Walther, L., Hahn, E., Ta, T. M. T., Bajbouj, M., & Von Scheve, C. (2021). The Challenged Sense of Belonging Scale (CSBS)—a validation study in English, Arabic, and Farsi/Dari among refugees and asylum seekers in Germany. *Measurement Instruments for the Social Sciences*, 3(1), 3. <https://doi.org/10.1186/s42409-021-00021-y>
- Geurts, N., Lubbers, M., & Spierings, N. (2020). Structural position and relative deprivation among recent migrants: A longitudinal take on the integration paradox. *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies*, 46(9), 1828–1848. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1369183X.2019.1675499>
- Granovetter, M. (1983). The Strength of Weak Ties: A Network Theory Revisited. *Sociological Theory*, 1, 201. <https://doi.org/10.2307/202051>
- Granovetter, M. S. (1973). The Strength of Weak Ties. *American Journal of Sociology*, 78(6), 1360–1380.
- Hagerty, B. M., Lynch-Sauer, J., Patusky, K. L., Bouwsema, M., & Collier, P. (1992). Sense of belonging: A vital mental health concept. *Archives of Psychiatric Nursing*, 6(3), 172–177. [https://doi.org/10.1016/0883-9417\(92\)90028-H](https://doi.org/10.1016/0883-9417(92)90028-H)
- Hainmueller, J., Hangartner, D., & Pietrantuono, G. (2015). Naturalization fosters the long-term political integration of immigrants. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 112(41), 12651–12656. <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1418794112>
- Hainmueller, J., Hangartner, D., & Pietrantuono, G. (2017). Catalyst or Crown: Does Naturalization Promote the Long-Term Social Integration of Immigrants? *American Political Science Review*, 111(2), 256–276. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055416000745>
- Hangartner, D., Dinas, E., Marbach, M., Matakos, K., & Xefteris, D. (2019). Does Exposure to the Refugee Crisis Make Natives More Hostile? *American Political Science Review*, 113(2), 442–455. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055418000813>
- Hannuksela, V., & Tiihonen, A. (2024). Minority bonding to political self-efficacy: A case study on bonding and bridging social capital and political self-efficacy among ad-

- olescents in Finland. *Frontiers in Political Science*, 5, 1270065. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpos.2023.1270065>
- Humphries, M., Muller, C., & Schiller, K. S. (2013). The Political Socialization of Adolescent Children of Immigrants. *Social Science Quarterly*, 94(5), 1261–1282. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ssqu.12025>
- Jiménez, H. (2011). Factors Influencing the Re-Emergence of Immigrant Rights Coalitions in the United States. *Journal of Immigrant & Refugee Studies*, 9(3), 267–290. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15562948.2011.592807>
- Jørgensen, A. B. (2026). Cross-ethnic integration through participation in leisure organisations? Evidence from two-wave panel data. *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies*, 52(7), 1902–1922. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1369183X.2025.2461649>
- Kymlicka, W. (1995). *Multicultural citizenship: A liberal theory of minority rights*. Oxford University Press.
- Lajevardi, N., Oskooii, K. A. R., Walker, H. L., & Westfall, A. L. (2020). The Paradox Between Integration and Perceived Discrimination Among American Muslims. *Political Psychology*, 41(3), 587–606. <https://doi.org/10.1111/pops.12640>
- Lancee, B. (2010). The Economic Returns of Immigrants' Bonding and Bridging Social Capital: The Case of the Netherlands. *International Migration Review*, 44(1), 202–226. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1747-7379.2009.00803.x>
- Lee, Y., & Kim-Leffingwell, S. (2025). Engaged but targeted? How immigrants vote against anti-immigrant agendas in Europe. *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies*, 1–25. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1369183X.2025.2589904>
- Mayorga, A. (2021). *Hostile Contexts and the Consequences for Muslim Political Integration* [Doctoral dissertation].
- Mc Kenzie, B. D. (2008). Reconsidering the Effects of Bonding Social Capital: A Closer Look at Black Civil Society Institutions in America. *Political Behavior*, 30(1), 25–45. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11109-007-9038-5>
- Oskooii, K. A. (2020). Perceived discrimination and political behavior. *British Journal of Political Science*, 50(3), 867–892.
- Panagopoulos, C., Fraser, T., Aldrich, D. P., Kim, D., & Hummel, D. (2022). Bridging the Divide: Does Social Capital Moderate the Impact of Polarization on Health? *Political Research Quarterly*, 75(3), 875–891. <https://doi.org/10.1177/10659129211034561>
- Pérez, E. O., & Vicuña, B. V. (2023). 25 The Gaze from Below: Toward a Political Psychology of Minority Status. In *The Oxford Handbook of Political Psychology*.
- Pettigrew, T. F., & Tropp, L. R. (2006). A meta-analytic test of intergroup contact theory. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 90(5), 751–783. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.90.5.751>
- Prati, F., Schaefer, S. J., Hewstone, M., & Christ, O. (2022). Antecedents of positive and negative intergroup contact: Evidence from a diary study. *International Journal of Psychology*, 57(4), 524–534. <https://doi.org/10.1002/ijop.12841>
- Putnam, R. D., Leonardi, R., & Nanetti, R. (1993). *Making democracy work: Civic traditions in modern Italy*. Princeton University Press.
- Putnam, R. D., Pharr, S. J., & Dalton, R. J. (2000). Introduction: What's Troubling the Tri-lateral Democracies? In R. D. Putnam & S. J. Pharr (Eds.), *Disaffected Democracies* (pp. 3–28). Princeton University Press. <https://doi.org/10.2307/j.ctv39x5n8.6>

- Reeskens, T., & Wright, M. (2013). Nationalism and the cohesive society: The interplay between diversity, national identity, and social capital across 27 European societies. *Comparative Political Studies*, 46(2), 153–181.
- Roman, M., Walker, H., & Barreto, M. (2022). How Social Ties with Undocumented Immigrants Motivate Latinx Political Participation. *Political Research Quarterly*, 75(3), 661–675. <https://doi.org/10.1177/10659129211019473>
- Schildkraut, D. J. (2005). The rise and fall of political engagement among latinos: The role of identity and perceptions of discrimination. *Political Behavior*, 27(3), 285–312.
- Schildkraut, D. J., Jiménez, T. R., Dovidio, J. F., & Huo, Y. J. (2019a). A tale of two states: How state immigration climate affects belonging to state and country among latinos. *Social Problems*, 66(3), 332–354.
- Schildkraut, D. J., Jiménez, T. R., Dovidio, J. F., & Huo, Y. J. (2019b). A tale of two states: How state immigration climate affects belonging to state and country among latinos. *Social Problems*, 66(3), 332–355.
- Scott, C., Bilodeau, A., Gagnon, A., & Turgeon, L. (2024). Minority Affirmations and the Boundaries of the Nation: Evidence From Québec. *Political Studies*, 00323217231223400. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00323217231223400>
- Simonsen, K. B. (2017). Does citizenship always further Immigrants' feeling of belonging to the host nation? A study of policies and public attitudes in 14 Western democracies. *Comparative Migration Studies*, 5(1), 3. <https://doi.org/10.1186/s40878-017-0050-6>
- Simonsen, K. B. (2019). "Us" or "Them"? How Policies, Public Opinion, and Political Rhetoric Affect Immigrants' Sense of Belonging (tech. rep.). Migration Policy Institute. <https://www.migrationpolicy.org/article/policies-public-opinion-rhetoric-immigrants-sense-belonging>
- Simonsen, K. B. (2021). The Democratic Consequences of Anti-immigrant Political Rhetoric: A Mixed Methods Study of Immigrants' Political Belonging. *Political Behavior*, 43(1), 143–174. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11109-019-09549-6>
- Skipworth, S. A., Garner, A., & Dettrey, B. J. (2010). Limitations of the Contact Hypothesis: Heterogeneity in the Contact Effect on Attitudes toward Gay Rights: Skipworth et al. / LIMITATIONS OF THE CONTACT HYPOTHESIS. *Politics & Policy*, 38(5), 887–906. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1747-1346.2010.00262.x>
- Sprecher, S. (2022). Acquaintanceships (weak ties): Their role in people's web of relationships and their formation. *Personal Relationships*, 29(3), 425–450. <https://doi.org/10.1111/pere.12430>
- Sumaktoyo, N. G. (2021). Friends from across the aisle: The effects of partisan bonding, partisan bridging, and network disagreement on outparty attitudes and political engagement. *Political Behavior*, 43(1), 223–245.
- Taylor, C., Gutmann, A., & Taylor, C. (1994). *Multiculturalism: Examining the politics of recognition*. Princeton University Press.
- Toikko, T., & Pehkonen, A. (2018). Community belongingness and subjective well-being among unemployed people in a Finnish community. *International Journal of Sociology and Social Policy*, 38(9/10), 754–765. <https://doi.org/10.1108/IJSSP-01-2018-0010>
- Verkuyten, M. (2016). The Integration Paradox: Empiric Evidence From the Netherlands. *American Behavioral Scientist*, 60(5-6), 583–596. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0002764216632838>

- Wright, M. (2011). Policy regimes and normative conceptions of nationalism in mass public opinion. *Comparative Political Studies*, 44(5), 598–624.
- Wu, Z., Hou, F., & Schimmele, C. M. (2011). Racial Diversity and Sense of Belonging in Urban Neighborhoods. *City & Community*, 10(4), 373–392. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1540-6040.2011.01374.x>
- Yuval-Davis, N. (2006). Belonging and the politics of belonging. *Patterns of Prejudice*, 40(3), 197–214. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00313220600769331>

A Comparing the City of Montreal and Outside

We checked the distribution and descriptive statistics of immigrants living in the city of Montreal and those who live outside (Table A1 and Figure A1). There were 1,307 immigrants living in the city of Montreal.

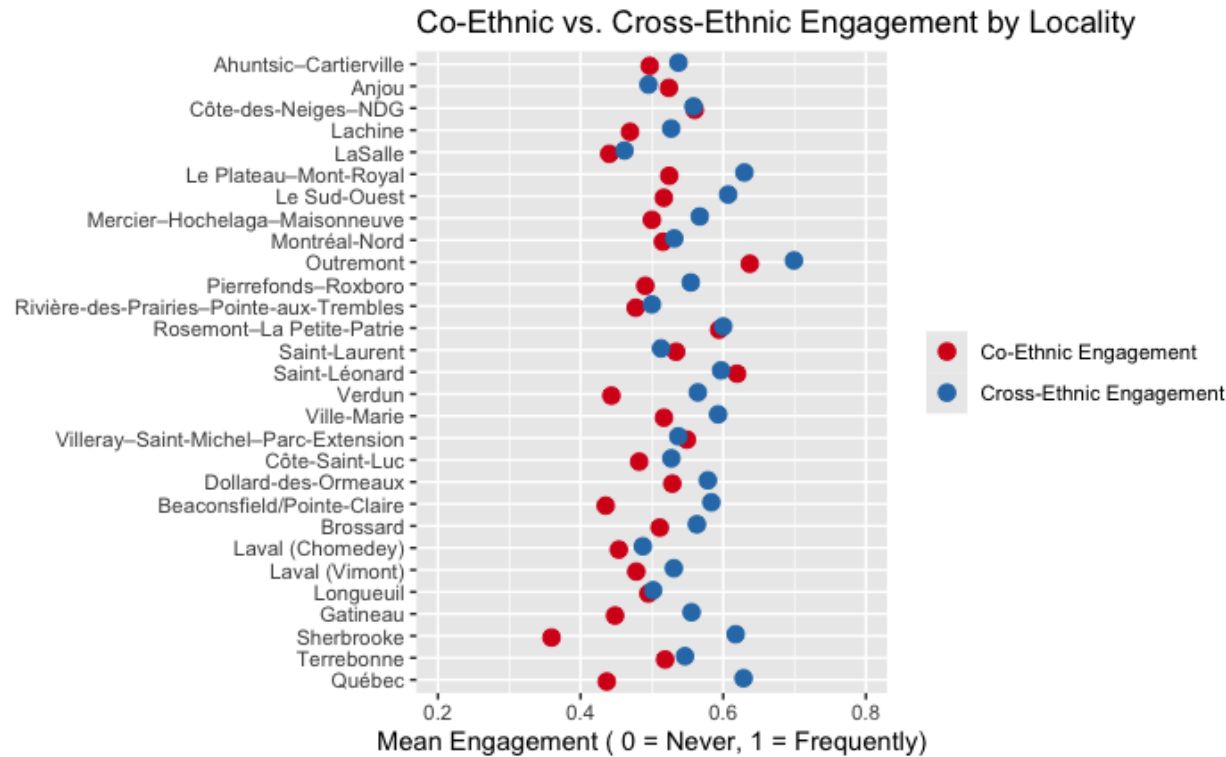


Figure A1: Co-Ethnic vs. Cross-Ethnic Engagement by Locality

Using the *strate* variable, we divided the samples into immigrants who live in the city of Montreal and those who live outside. Table A1 compares key demographic and attitudinal variables between immigrants residing in Montreal and those elsewhere in Quebec. Immigrants in Montreal are younger (50 vs. 55 years), more likely to be recent arrivals, and report higher co-ethnic interactions. In contrast, cross-ethnic interaction does not differ significantly between the two groups. Respondents outside Montreal show marginally stronger feelings of attachment and acceptance toward their community and Quebec. No significant differences appear for language proficiency or gender composition.

Table A1: T-tests Comparing Montreal vs. Outside-Montreal Immigrants

Variable	Rest of Quebec	Montreal	<i>t</i>	df	<i>p</i>
Number of Respondents	758	1,307	–	–	–
Co-ethnic Interaction	4.800	5.170	-4.679	1472.9	0.000
Cross-ethnic Interaction	5.320	5.333	-0.163	1459.5	0.870
Ratio	12.660	11.756	2.861	1302.2	0.004
Cross-Ethnic Friends	2.900	2.944	-1.008	1488.7	0.313
Co-Ethnic Friends	2.772	2.972	-4.422	1453.7	0.000
Age	54.902	50.421	6.081	1703.5	0.000
Male	0.419	0.435	-0.734	1584.8	0.463
Education	6.144	6.075	0.805	1546.7	0.421
Recent Arrivals	0.128	0.233	-6.173	1870.1	0.000
Racial Minority	0.528	0.592	-2.794	1542.1	0.005
Acceptance — Montreal	0.846	0.823	2.615	1650.2	0.009
Acceptance — Quebec	0.783	0.748	3.314	1669.9	0.001
Acceptance — Canada	0.849	0.836	1.556	1666.3	0.120
Attachment — Montreal	0.765	0.738	2.499	1577.4	0.013
Attachment — Quebec	0.810	0.791	1.968	1663.3	0.049
Attachment — Canada	0.849	0.830	2.323	1702.3	0.020
French Proficiency	8.447	8.547	-0.982	1568.5	0.326
English Proficiency	6.738	6.870	-1.026	1512.8	0.305

B Descriptive Analyses

B.1 Social Interaction Among Immigrants

The figure illustrates the distribution of interaction with both co-ethnic and cross-ethnic individuals in sports, cultural activities, and socializing with friends. On average, immigrants report slightly more frequent interaction with cross-ethnic friends (mean = 0.65) than with co-ethnic friends (mean = 0.64), but almost the same. Participation in sports and cultural activities is less frequent overall, particularly with co-ethnic contacts (mean = 0.38) compared to cross-ethnic activities (mean = 0.47). Overall, friendship-based interactions are more common than activity-based interaction.

C Regression Specification: Education as Continuous

Table A2 reports the main regression models with education entered as the original 8-point continuous variable rather than as a binary university indicator. Results are substantively unchanged.

Table A2: Fixed-Effects Estimates with Education as Continuous Variable

	Neighborhood			Quebec			Canada		
	Basic	Demo	Full	Basic	Demo	Full	Basic	Demo	Full
Cross-Ethnic Friends	0.070*** (0.017)	0.042*** (0.016)	0.031** (0.015)	0.072*** (0.018)	0.047*** (0.017)	0.038** (0.017)	0.059*** (0.014)	0.049*** (0.014)	0.032** (0.014)
Co-Ethnic Friends	-0.025 (0.016)	-0.006 (0.015)	0.002 (0.015)	-0.028 (0.018)	-0.008 (0.017)	0.007 (0.016)	0.012 (0.014)	0.018 (0.013)	0.024* (0.013)
Cross-Ethnic Activities	0.003 (0.015)	0.017 (0.014)	0.013 (0.014)	0.025 (0.017)	0.044*** (0.016)	0.031** (0.015)	-0.017 (0.013)	-0.003 (0.013)	-0.006 (0.013)
Co-Ethnic Activities	-0.009 (0.015)	0.014 (0.014)	0.024* (0.014)	-0.045*** (0.017)	-0.024 (0.016)	-0.010 (0.015)	-0.021 (0.013)	-0.013 (0.013)	-0.003 (0.013)
French Proficiency			0.066*** (0.019)			0.161*** (0.020)			0.066*** (0.017)
English Proficiency			0.023 (0.016)			-0.042** (0.017)			0.073*** (0.014)
Male		-0.045*** (0.008)	-0.047*** (0.008)		-0.022** (0.009)	-0.022*** (0.009)		-0.023*** (0.007)	-0.026*** (0.007)
Education (8-pt)		-0.003 (0.002)	-0.004* (0.002)		-0.006** (0.003)	-0.004* (0.002)		-0.009*** (0.002)	-0.011*** (0.002)
Age		0.002*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.000)		0.002*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.000)		0.001*** (0.000)	0.001*** (0.000)
Recent Immigrant		-0.050*** (0.012)	-0.042*** (0.011)		-0.012 (0.013)	-0.003 (0.012)		-0.006 (0.010)	0.006 (0.010)
Racialized Minority		-0.014 (0.009)	0.006 (0.009)		-0.027*** (0.010)	0.009 (0.010)		0.006 (0.008)	0.025*** (0.008)
Muslim Identity		0.037*** (0.011)	0.034*** (0.011)		-0.030** (0.012)	-0.043*** (0.012)		0.049*** (0.010)	0.051*** (0.010)
Perceived Discrimination			-0.068*** (0.008)			-0.119*** (0.009)			-0.058*** (0.008)
Web Mode		-0.073*** (0.009)	-0.067*** (0.009)		-0.062*** (0.011)	-0.053*** (0.010)		-0.032*** (0.008)	-0.027*** (0.008)
N	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795
R ²	0.014	0.154	0.191	0.020	0.126	0.242	0.014	0.073	0.123
Adj. R ²	-0.004	0.135	0.172	0.002	0.107	0.224	-0.004	0.052	0.102

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Standard errors clustered at the locality level in parentheses.

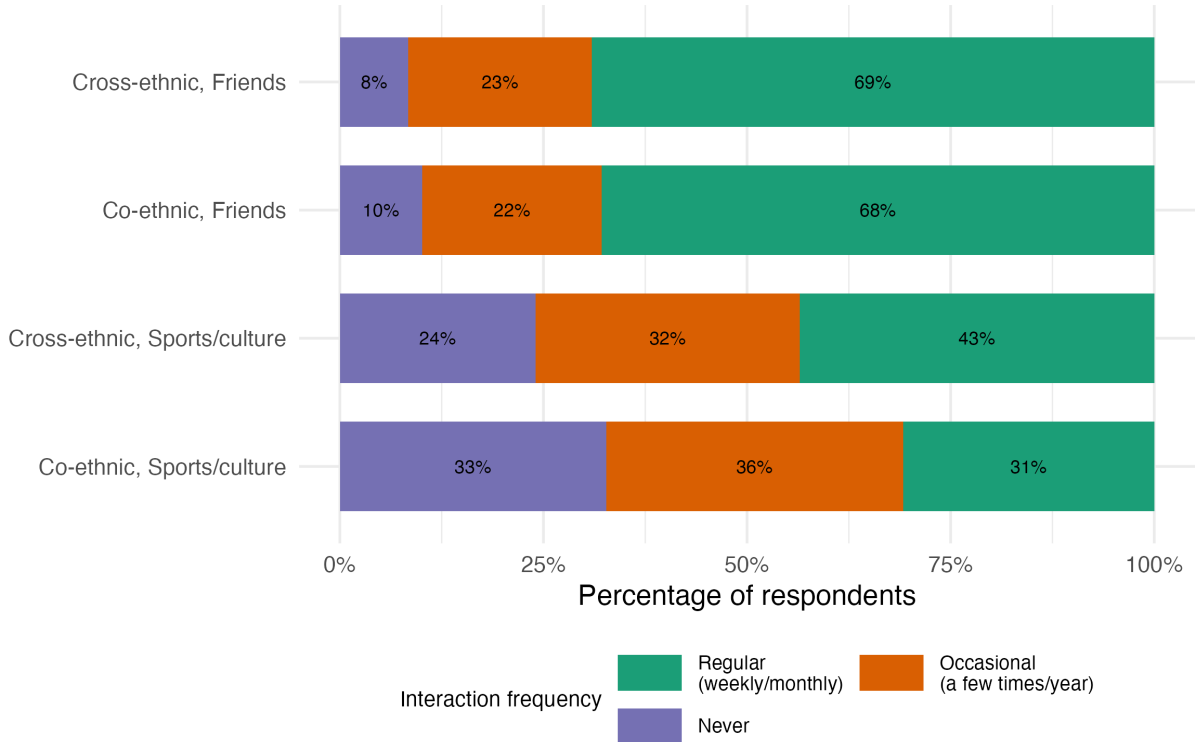


Figure A2: Distribution of Interaction with Co-Ethnics and cross-Ethnics

D Main Analyses

As a robustness check, we re-estimate the main models on a combined belonging index that averages the attachment and acceptance items at each level. This collapses the two dimensions analyzed separately in the main text and shows that the level-specific pattern is not an artifact of the decomposition.

Figure A3 and A4 display coefficient estimates for friendship-based and activity-based interactions from these full models, with 95% confidence intervals.

D.0.1 Friendship-Based Interactions and Belonging

Figure A3 shows the coefficients for cross-ethnic and co-ethnic friendships across the three levels of belonging. Cross-ethnic friendship is positively associated with belonging at all three levels: at Quebec ($\beta = 0.039, p < 0.05$), at Canada ($\beta = 0.032, p < 0.05$), and at the locality ($\beta = 0.032, p < 0.05$). The Quebec coefficient is slightly larger than the Canada coefficient, but the difference is modest. The substantive picture is that cross-ethnic friendship operates across both political levels of integration and at the apolitical local baseline, consistent with the friendship results in the main text. Friendship-based contact with members of the host society signals personal recognition that translates into belonging re-

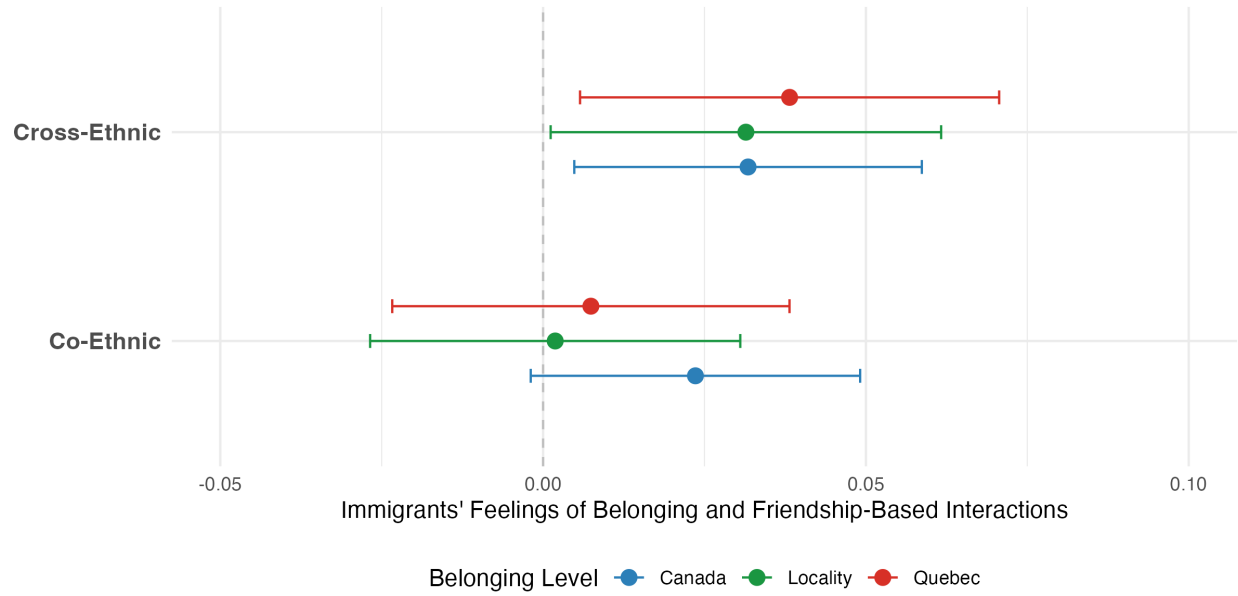


Figure A3: Coefficient Estimates of Friendship-Based Interactions on Belonging Across Three Levels

ardless of whether the host society’s integration framework legitimizes multiple ethnic identities (Canada) or demands convergence toward a common public culture (Quebec).

Co-ethnic friendship shows a different pattern. It is positively associated with belonging to Canada ($\beta = 0.024, p < 0.1$) but not with belonging to Quebec ($\beta = 0.008, p > 0.1$) or to the locality ($\beta = 0.002, p > 0.1$). This mirrors the co-ethnic pattern reported above. In Canada’s multicultural framework, where the maintenance of ethnic-community interactions is explicitly compatible with national identification, co-ethnic friendships register as belonging-supporting. In Quebec’s interculturalist framework, the same friendships are not associated with provincial belonging, consistent with the framework’s prediction that bonding ties are politically orthogonal where integration is framed around convergence rather than plurality.

The contrast between cross-ethnic and co-ethnic friendship is the clearest expression of the plus-sum/zero-sum logic in the data. Cross-ethnic friendship matters everywhere. Co-ethnic friendship matters only where the host society’s integration framework legitimizes ethnic-community ties.

D.0.2 Activity-Based Interactions and Belonging

Figure A4 shows the coefficients for participation in sports and cultural activities. The pattern is more limited than for friendship and more context-dependent. Cross-ethnic activities are positively associated with belonging to Quebec ($\beta = 0.029, p < 0.1$) but not with belonging to Canada ($\beta = -0.008, p > 0.1$) or to the locality ($\beta = 0.010, p > 0.1$).

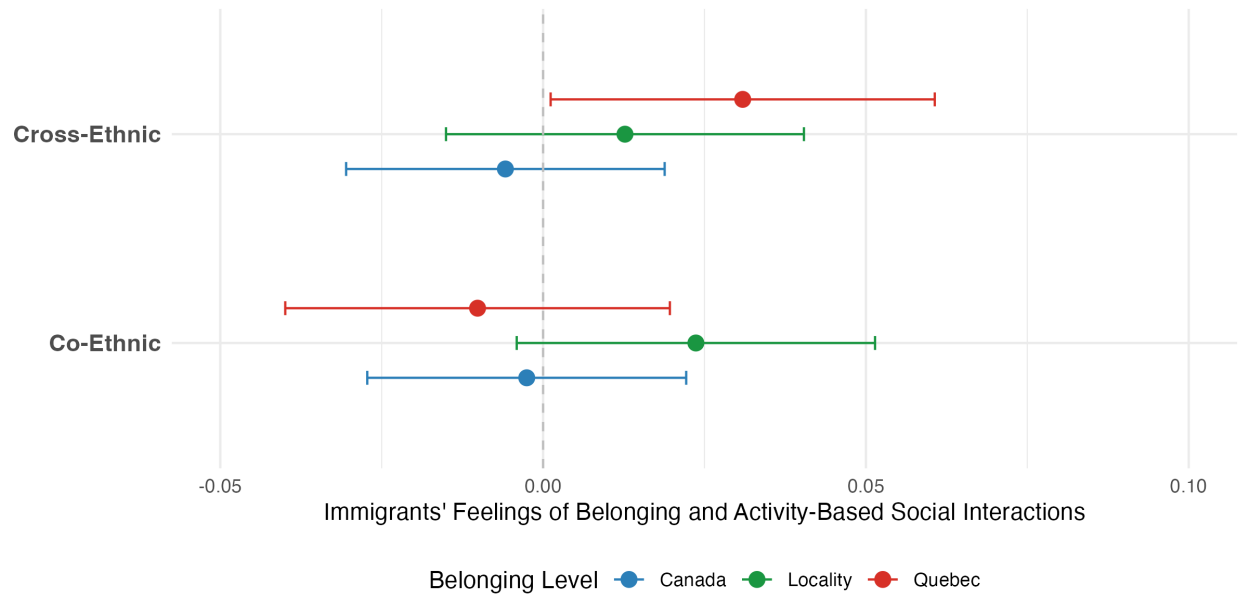


Figure A4: Coefficient Estimates of Activity-Based Interactions on Belonging Across Three Levels

Activity-based contact in shared cultural and athletic spaces is politically legible in Quebec’s interculturalist framework, which centers integration on participation in a common public culture. The same form of contact is not similarly legible at the Canadian national level, where multiculturalism does not require participation in shared cultural spaces to signal integration. Co-ethnic activities are not significantly associated with belonging at any of the three levels. The coefficients are small and statistically indistinguishable from zero at Quebec ($\beta = -0.010$), Canada ($\beta = -0.002$), and the locality ($\beta = 0.024$, $p < 0.1$ but marginally so). Co-ethnic activities, the weakest form of bonding contact, do not generate belonging at any political level.

These findings together suggest that not all forms of social interaction carry the same weight. Friendship-based contact has more consistent effects than activity-based contact, both because friendship is a more intensive form of contact and because cross-ethnic friendship signals personal recognition that is legible regardless of the host society’s integration framework. Activity-based contact, by contrast, generates politically meaningful effects only where the integration framework explicitly values shared participation in common cultural spaces, which in our data is Quebec.

E Settlement Stage and Social Interactions

E.1 Variation Across Settlement Stages

Because immigrants' opportunities for social interaction and political incorporation evolve over time, the relationship between social interaction and belonging may differ across stages of settlement. We, therefore, explore whether recent or established immigrants differ in how each form of social interaction is associated with belonging. For this analysis, we categorize immigrants as recent (arrived within the last 10 years) and established (10+ years in Canada).

We motivate this extension with a formative-experiences argument. Research on immigrant political integration consistently shows that the timing of integration-relevant experiences matters for long-term outcomes (Hainmueller et al., 2015, 2017; Humphries et al., 2013; Lee & Kim-Leffingwell, 2025). Bratsberg et al. (2021) show that immigrants' initial neighborhoods shape later political integration, while Ferwerda et al. (2020) find similar long-term effects of early access to voting rights. We extend this logic to everyday social interaction. Because attachment and acceptance capture different aspects of belonging, they may also evolve differently over the settlement process. Feelings of acceptance reflect whether immigrants feel recognized by others and may respond similarly to social interactions regardless of how long they have lived in Canada. Attachment, by contrast, develops more gradually as immigrants establish their lives in the host society. As a result, social interactions may play a larger role in shaping attachment among recent immigrants than among established immigrants, whose sense of attachment has had more time to develop. We therefore expect differences across settlement stages to be more evident for attachment than for acceptance.

To test this expectation, we estimate interaction models including all four social interaction measures, their interactions with a recent-immigrant indicator, the full set of covariates, and locality fixed effects. Full results for both attachment and acceptance across all three levels are reported in Table A3 in Appendix E.1. Consistent with our expectation, none of the interaction terms are statistically significant for acceptance at any level, although the coefficients for cross-ethnic friendship at the Quebec and Canada levels are positive. By contrast, three interaction terms are statistically significant for attachment, revealing a consistent pattern across levels.

Figure A5 presents predicted levels of attachment for recent and established immigrants at low and high levels of cross-ethnic friendship. The results differ across the three political levels in ways that are consistent with our theoretical expectations.

At the Canada level, recent immigrants who form more cross-ethnic friendships report stronger attachment than established immigrants ($\beta = 0.081, p < 0.10$). Moving from low to high levels of cross-ethnic friendship is associated with an increase of roughly 0.09 points in attachment among recent immigrants, compared with a much smaller increase among established immigrants. This pattern suggests that cross-ethnic friendships matter

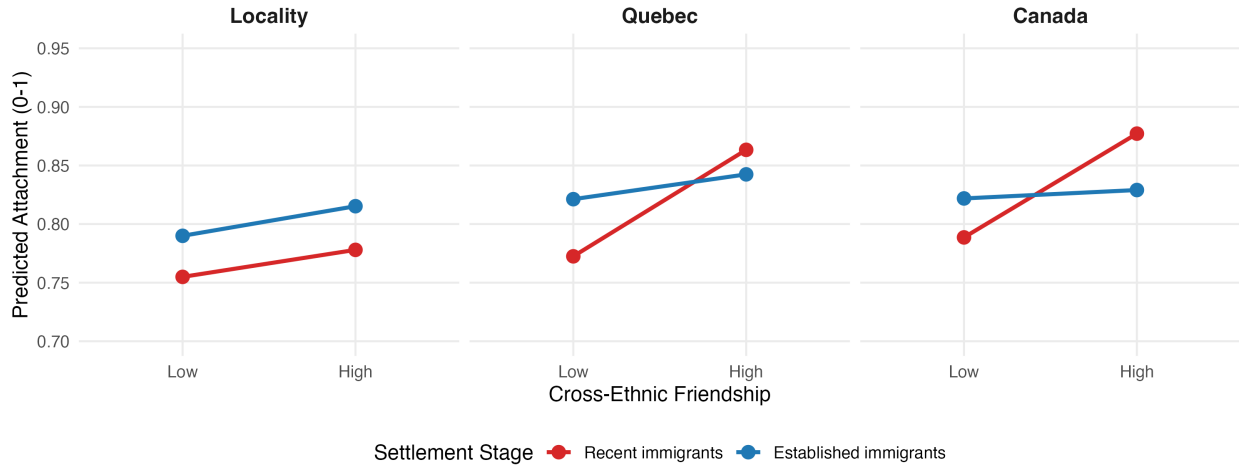


Figure A5: Predicted Attachment by Cross-Ethnic Friendship and Settlement Stage. Recent immigrants show a substantially steeper positive slope at the Canada level than established immigrants. Neighborhood and Quebec slopes are more comparable across settlement stages.

most during the early years of settlement, when immigrants are still developing a sense of belonging to Canada.

The Canada results also reveal an interesting difference between cross-ethnic and co-ethnic friendships. Among recent immigrants, greater reliance on co-ethnic friendships is associated with lower attachment to Canada ($\beta = -0.084, p < 0.10$), whereas co-ethnic friendship is positively associated with Canadian attachment in the full sample ($\beta = 0.051, p < 0.01$). One possible interpretation is that recent immigrants rely more heavily on either bridging or bonding ties during the early stages of settlement, while these forms of social connection become complementary over time. Because this interaction is only marginally significant, we view this as a tentative pattern rather than a firm conclusion.

The third significant interaction appears at the neighborhood level. Recent immigrants who participate more in cross-ethnic activities report stronger attachment to their neighborhood ($\beta = 0.129, p < 0.05$). This finding is consistent with the idea that neighborhood belonging develops through everyday interactions. For recent immigrants, participating in shared activities may help build local familiarity more quickly than it does for immigrants who have already lived in the same communities for many years.

Taken together, these results provide partial support for H6a: cross-ethnic friendship is more strongly associated with attachment among recent immigrants at the Canada level, though not at the other levels. We find no support for H6b; none of the interaction terms for acceptance reach significance. The moderation is concentrated on attachment, consistent with our expectation that settlement stage matters more for attachment than for acceptance.

Table A3 reports the full interaction models underlying the settlement-stage analysis in

the main text, with all four social interaction measures, their interactions with the recent-immigrant indicator, the full set of covariates, and locality fixed effects, estimated separately for attachment and acceptance at each level.

Table A3: Fixed-Effects Interaction Models: Social Interactions and Settlement Stage

	Attachment			Acceptance		
	Local	QC	CA	Local	QC	CA
Cross-Ethnic Friends	0.025 (0.022)	0.021 (0.020)	0.007 (0.018)	0.043** (0.018)	0.030 (0.021)	0.037** (0.017)
Co-Ethnic Friends	0.010 (0.020)	0.023 (0.019)	0.051*** (0.017)	-0.005 (0.017)	-0.013 (0.020)	0.003 (0.016)
Cross-Ethnic Activities	-0.007 (0.020)	0.024 (0.018)	-0.019 (0.016)	0.009 (0.016)	0.049*** (0.019)	0.013 (0.015)
Co-Ethnic Activities	0.031 (0.020)	-0.014 (0.019)	-0.004 (0.017)	0.018 (0.017)	-0.013 (0.019)	0.011 (0.016)
Recent Immigrant	-0.059 (0.037)	-0.047 (0.035)	0.019 (0.031)	-0.048 (0.031)	-0.044 (0.036)	0.008 (0.029)
Cross-Ethnic Friends × Recent	-0.002 (0.052)	0.070 (0.048)	0.081* (0.043)	-0.040 (0.043)	0.063 (0.050)	0.048 (0.041)
Co-Ethnic Friends × Recent	-0.035 (0.053)	0.001 (0.050)	-0.084* (0.044)	0.011 (0.044)	0.040 (0.051)	0.023 (0.042)
Cross-Ethnic Activities × Recent	0.129** (0.050)	-0.010 (0.047)	0.017 (0.042)	0.027 (0.042)	-0.075 (0.049)	-0.056 (0.040)
Co-Ethnic Activities × Recent	-0.040 (0.047)	0.007 (0.044)	-0.017 (0.039)	0.017 (0.039)	0.031 (0.045)	-0.053 (0.037)
N	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795	1795
R^2	0.155	0.173	0.095	0.165	0.246	0.131
Adj. R^2	0.133	0.151	0.071	0.143	0.226	0.108

Note: Standard errors clustered at the locality level in parentheses. Local = Locality; QC = Quebec; CA = Canada. All models include covariates for age, gender, education, racialized minority status, Muslim identity, French and English proficiency, perceived discrimination, and survey mode. * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

F Settlement Stage and the Returns to Cross-Ethnic Friendship

Figure A6 shows that cross-ethnic friendship is more strongly associated with belonging among recent immigrants. Moving from low to high levels of cross-ethnic friendship is associated with an increase of approximately 0.11 points in belonging to Quebec among recent immigrants, compared to 0.05 points among established immigrants. A similar but smaller pattern appears at the Canada level: recent immigrants gain about 0.06 points while established immigrants gain about 0.03 points. At the neighborhood level, the slopes for the two groups are roughly parallel, with recent immigrants reporting lower baseline

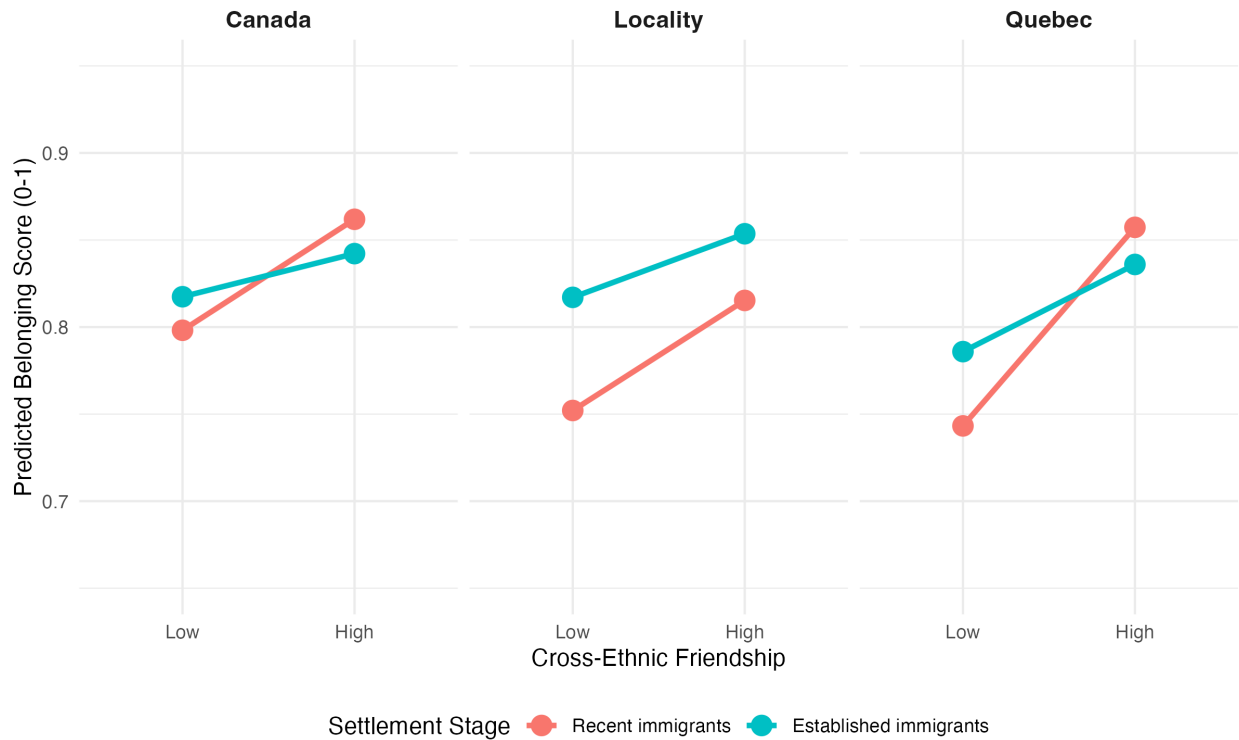


Figure A6: Predicted Belonging by Cross-Ethnic Friendship and Settlement Stage

belonging at low levels of cross-ethnic friendship but similar gains as their cross-ethnic friendships increase.

This pattern is consistent with the formative-experiences account (Humphries et al., 2013; Lee & Kim-Leffingwell, 2025). For newcomers who have not yet accumulated host-society experiences, institutional familiarity, or established social networks, early cross-ethnic friendships may serve as a particularly salient signal of social recognition and inclusion. The differential return is most pronounced at the Quebec level, where the convergence-oriented integration framework places more demanding expectations on immigrants, though we acknowledge that other features of Quebec’s context, including language politics and immigrant residential concentration, may also shape these patterns. As immigrants settle over time, belonging is shaped by a wider accumulation of experiences, and any single type of interaction is correspondingly less pivotal. This logic parallels findings in the broader literature on immigrant political integration, where the integrative effects of early-settlement contexts tend to dissipate over time as immigrants accumulate their own experiences (Andersson et al., 2022).

We also examined whether cross-ethnic activities and co-ethnic interactions show analogous moderation by settlement stage. The results, reported in Appendix E.1, do not reveal systematic moderation patterns consistent with the formative-experiences argument. Cross-ethnic activities are associated with modest and similar gains across recent and established immigrants. Co-ethnic friendship and co-ethnic activities show inconsis-

ent moderation patterns across the three belonging levels. The settlement-stage moderation is therefore specific to cross-ethnic friendship, which is consistent with friendship being the most personally meaningful form of social interaction.

For completeness, we report moderation analyses for cross-ethnic activities and co-ethnic interactions by settlement stage. None of these analyses reveal systematic moderation patterns consistent with the formative-experiences argument. Figure A7 shows that cross-ethnic activities lead to modest and similar gains across recent and established immigrants. Figures A8 and A9 show inconsistent moderation patterns for co-ethnic friendship and co-ethnic activities, with no clear theoretical interpretation.



Figure A7: Predicted Belonging by Cross-Ethnic Activity and Settlement Stage

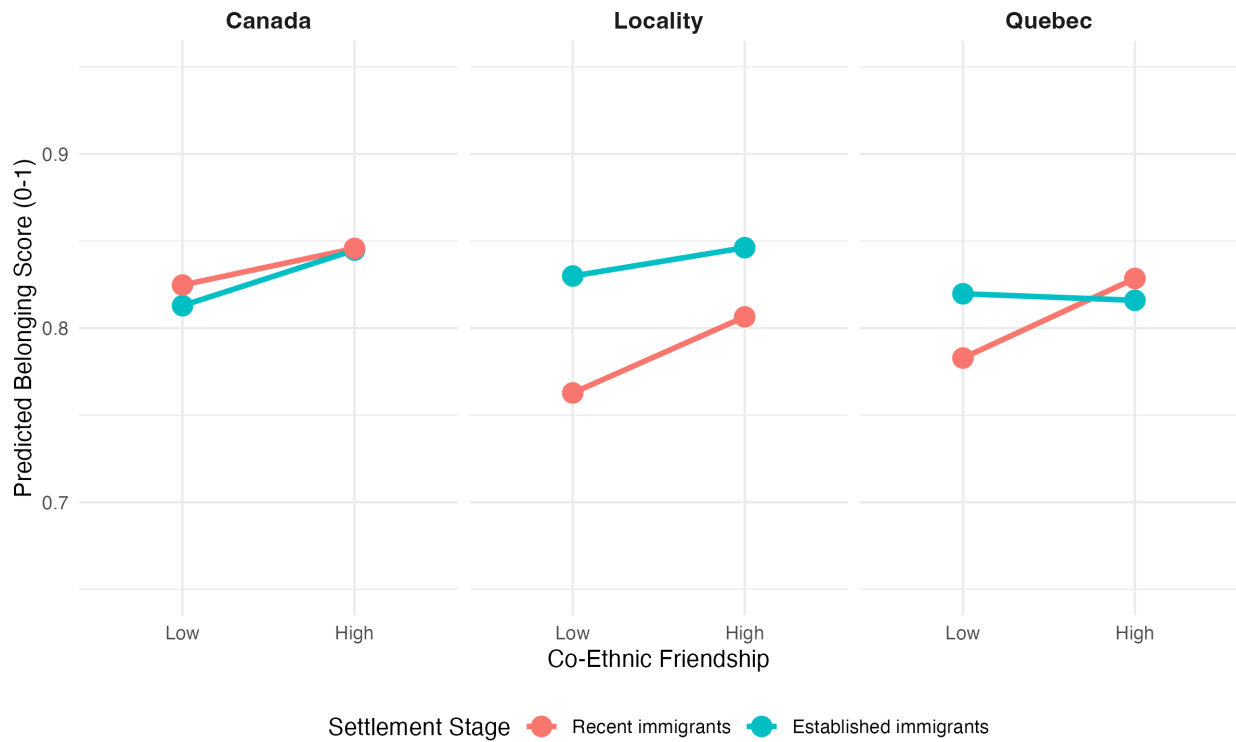


Figure A8: Predicted Belonging by Co-Ethnic Friendship and Settlement Stage

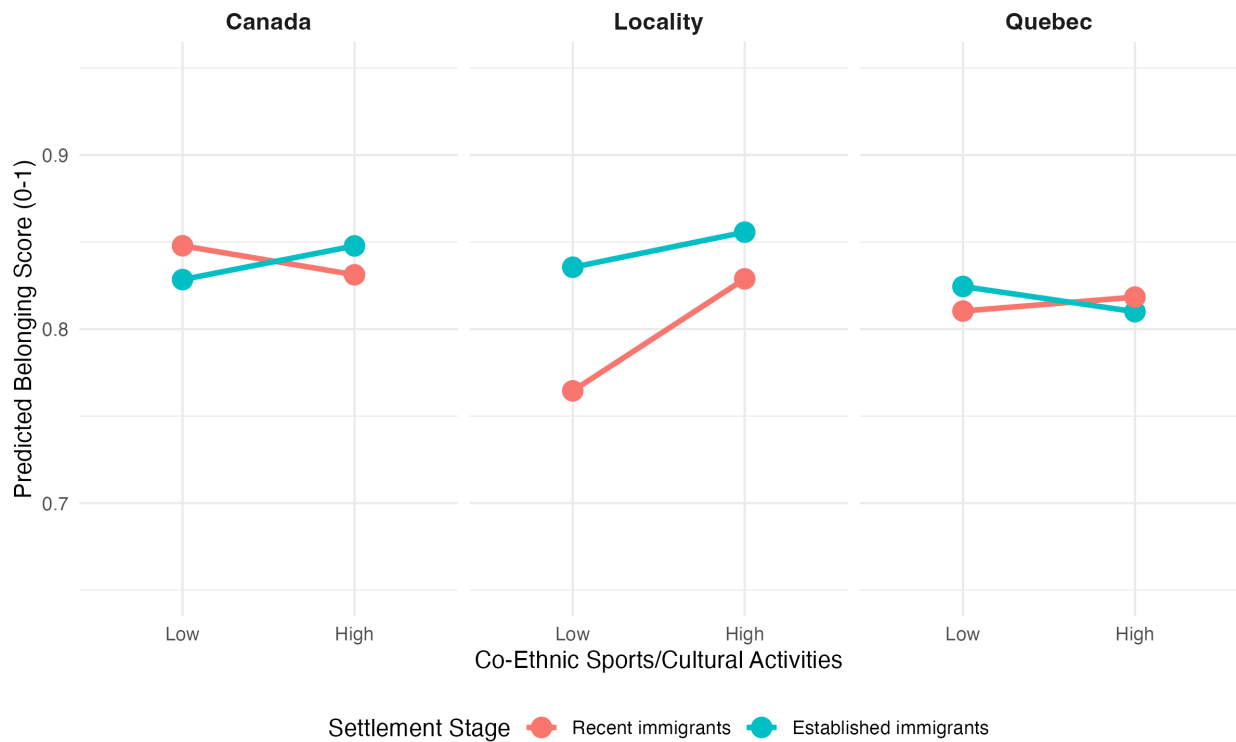


Figure A9: Predicted Belonging by Co-Ethnic Activity and Settlement Stage